



MONEY IN WOMEN'S SPORT

STATISTA DOSSIERPLUS ON MONEY IN WOMEN'S SPORT
AND THE GENDER PAY GAP

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The expanding world of women's sport: attendances and revenues are on the up, but do the salaries reflect this?

Executive summary

For years, women's professional sport has existed in the shadow of its male counterpart. Lower attendances, fewer television viewers, and a lack of brand engagement has left women's professional leagues constantly fighting for their existence and the athletes themselves fighting to establish a livelihood. However, the tide is slowly turning: Global women's tournaments such as the soccer World Cup attract millions of TV viewers, and brands have begun to take notice of the marketability of the world's top female athletes.

The growth of women's sport must start at the very bottom at grassroots level. The introduction of Title IX in 1972 began to level the college playing field for female athletes and gave them access to scholarships and funding previously reserved for the top male football and basketball stars. However, almost 40 years later, female athletes are still outnumbered by their male peers, and female coaches have been slowly forced out of the now lucrative world of college sports coaching.

- This disparity permeates from the amateur game into professional sports. Across the board, a gender pay gap exists between male and female athletes playing the same sport, with several recurring trends arising: The pay inequality is often justified by the lower marketability and revenues of any given women's league. But with less money invested in the women's game from the beginning, a slower growth is to be expected. Less money generated means lower wages for the

female athletes – average salaries in the Men's National Basketball Association, for example, are over one hundred times larger than in the Women's National Basketball Association.

- Even in sports with an equal prize pot, female athletes take home less money. Male athletes negotiate higher sponsorship deals and brand partnerships – tennis stars Roger Federer and Serena Williams are both at the top of their games, but Federer's sponsorship worth is 86 million U.S. dollars to Williams' 25 million U.S. dollars. What is it that makes male athletes more marketable than female athletes?
- The pay dispute between the United States women's soccer team and its federation has turned the topic of inequality in sport into a very public and heated discussion. How will other teams and sports react to this crisis?
- Professional women's sport has become much more than just about success on the field – it has become a celebration of female empowerment and strength. How have brands been tapping into this idea to make women's sport more marketable and popular?

This DossierPlus will examine all these ideas, as well as providing an outlook about what direction women's sport is heading.



01 College sport

- College athletes
- Title IX
- Scholarships

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No person in the United States shall, on the basis of sex, be excluded from participation in, be denied the benefits of, or be subjected to discrimination under any education program or activity receiving Federal financial assistance.

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—

Cornell Law School's Legal Information Institute

(20 U.S. Code § 1681 - Sex) as signed into law by
President Richard Nixon in 1972

College scholarships and the impact of Title IX

What is Title IX and how did it change the face of college sports?

College sports is a big business in the United States. Gifted athletes compete for prestigious sports scholarships which help them to pay for college tuition fees that can run into the tens of thousands of U.S. dollars. Athletic scholarships mostly fall under the remit of the National Collegiate Athletic Association (NCAA), which splits its members into three divisions. Only colleges in the NCAA's top two divisions have the ability to award sporting scholarships. The largest universities with a minimum of 14 sports for male and female students are classified as Division I schools. These universities heavily invest in sports facilities, offer more scholarships, and have large budgets.

Historically, football, a male-only college sport, has been awarded the most scholarships because it generates the most revenue for the NCAA. Other sports such as basketball and baseball were also heavily favored due to their popularity among both participants and viewers. As a result, talented female athletes were missing out on scholarships that were instead awarded in male-only sports, and fewer than 30,000 female athletes competed in intercollegiate sports in 1972.

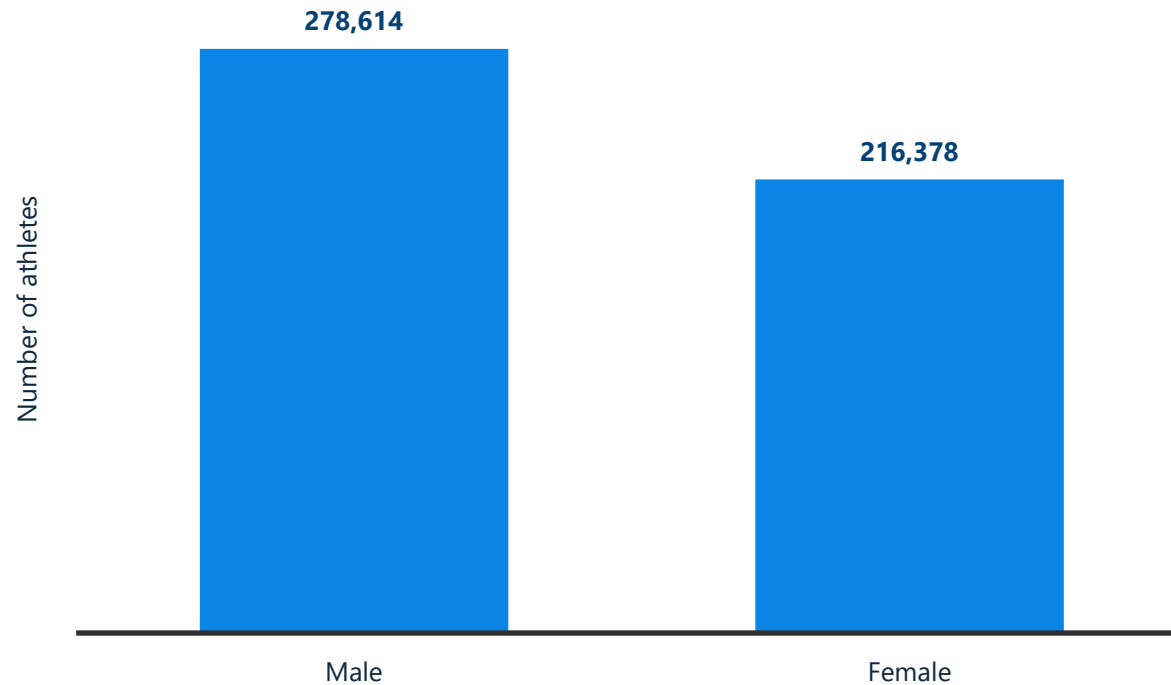
Following the passage of the Civil Rights Act in 1964, Title IX was passed as part of the Education Amendments of 1972. By banning any form of discrimination based on gender in programs receiving federal funding, Title IX gave female athletes the right to equal opportunities when it came

to college sports scholarships. The passing of this law has undoubtedly led to a surge in female athletes – latest NCAA figures put the number of female college athletes at over 216,000, a significant increase from pre-Title IX times. However, with women making up significantly more than half of college enrolment in the United States, these figures do not tell the whole story; male athletes still outnumber their female counterparts, and there are more college sports scholarships available to men than women.

The caveats that have come with Title IX's perceived success do not end there: The law led to a surge in new women's college teams and programs with more resources and funds at their disposal, prompting many colleges to combine their male and female sports departments. As a result, these departments were put under the leadership of one athletics director who, in almost 90 percent of cases in Division I, was male. Even on the sidelines, leadership positions in women's college sport became a more tempting and lucrative prospect. Ambitious male coaches, who had previously only seen men's college sport as a way to progress their careers, now saw the appeal of women's sport. The female coaches who had previously occupied these positions, however, did not experience the same increase in opportunities in male college programs.

45 years after Title IX, male college athletes still outnumber their female counterparts

There were over 60,000 more male than female NCAA student athletes in 2018

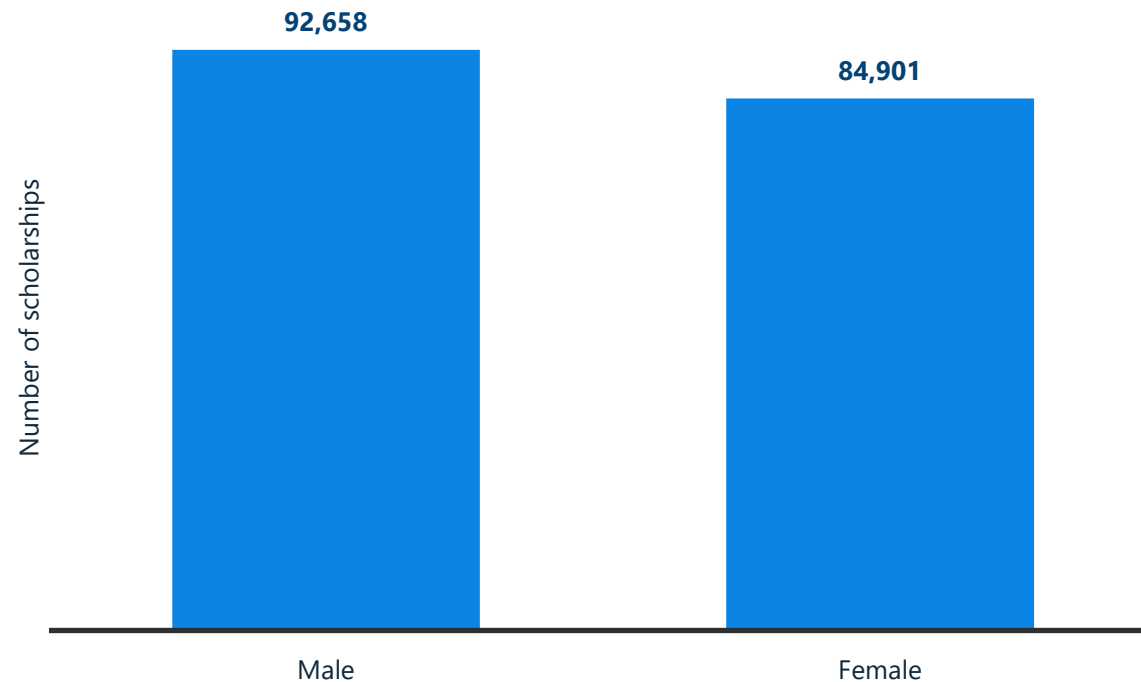


Despite a lower college population, men still dominate the sports field

In recent years, college enrolment has been significantly higher for women than for men. However, this distribution is not reflected in the number of collegiate athletes. Of the almost 495,000 students competing in NCAA sports in the 2017-18 academic year, some 56 percent were male. While Title IX has significantly increased female participation in college sports since its passing in 1972, it seems that there is still some way to go to level the playing field. There are several factors which may contribute to this discrepancy between male and female college athletes, including less support and fewer opportunities for young girls to pursue a sporting career, a lack of female role models within the sports industry, and fewer college sports scholarship opportunities for women.

More scholarships for male athletes, with football dominating the field

More male scholarships reflects the higher number of male athletes, but it does not tell the whole story



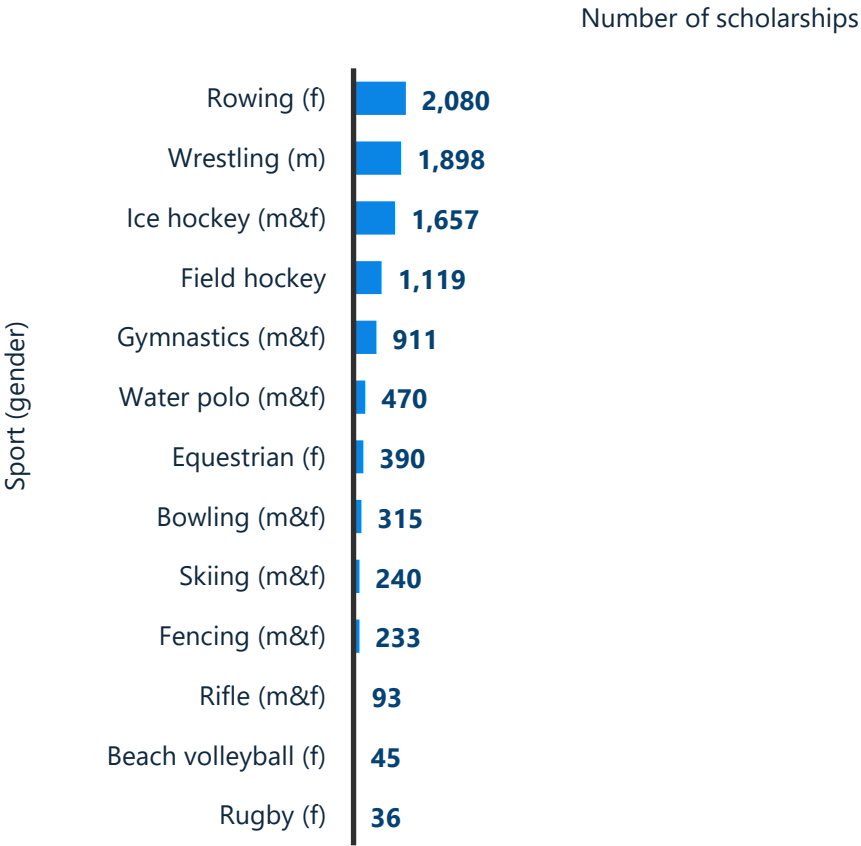
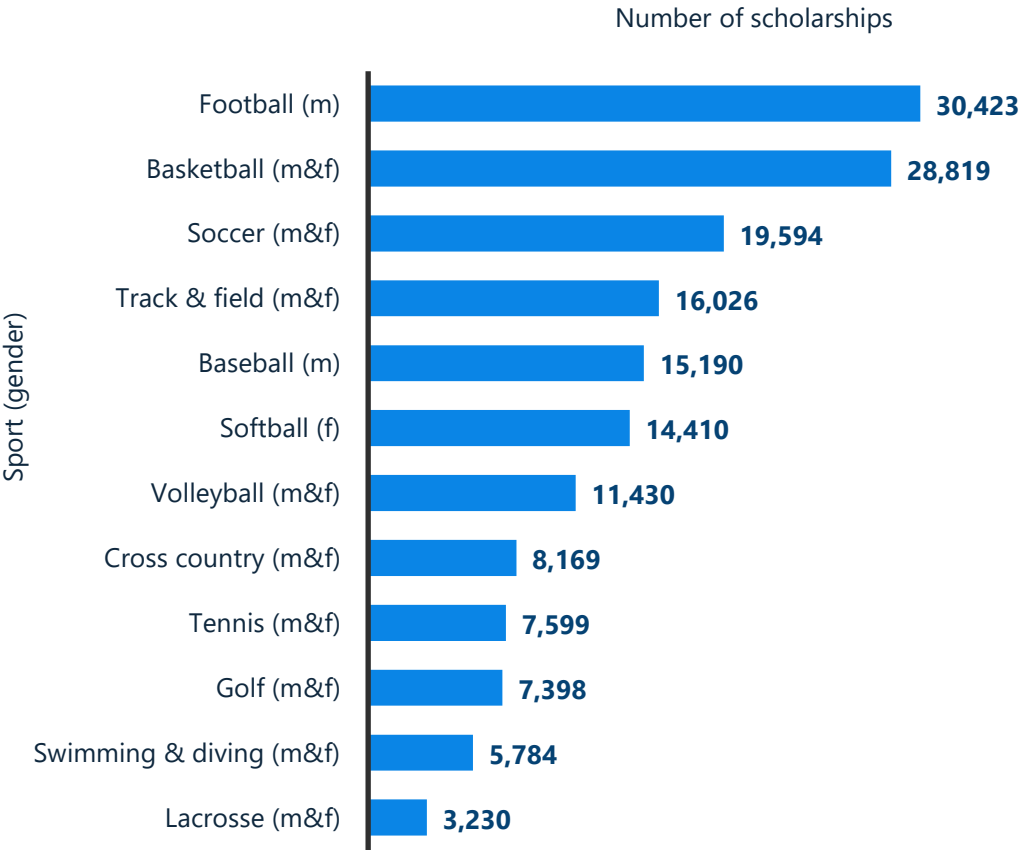
Does a lack of scholarships discourage female athletes?

The perceived lack of scholarship opportunities for female athletes could be a stumbling block for initial college applications. The huge financial burden of college tuition and the lack of a guaranteed sporting career after graduation could discourage female athletes from taking the college route in the first place, thereby creating a lack of female college athletes.

Conversely, a football scholarship for a gifted male athlete is seen as a stepping stone to a potential lucrative career in the NFL and the next logical step for any promising male athlete at high school – with over 30,000 scholarships available for male football players. Yet for women's basketball and soccer, two of the more profitable women's professional set-ups, there are just over 25,000 scholarships combined (see next page).

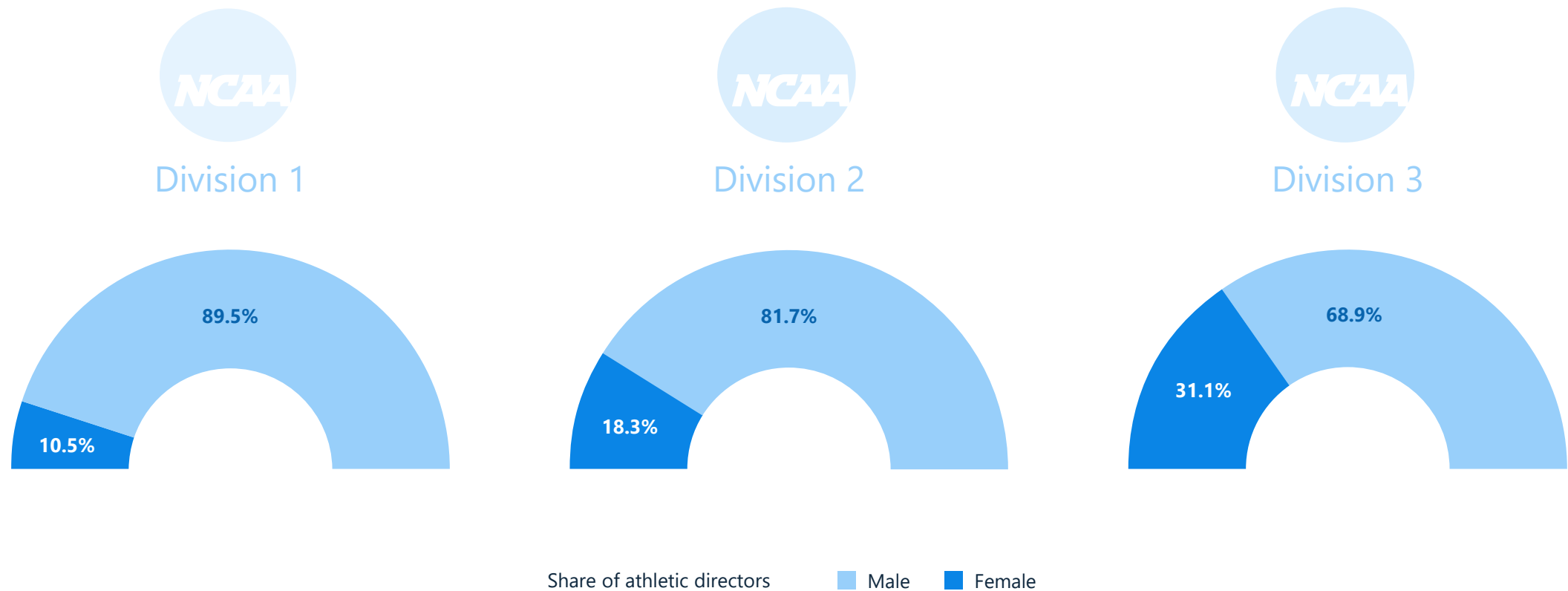
Football and baseball lead the way for male-only sports scholarships

Softball is the best-represented female-only sport, but it still lags behind baseball



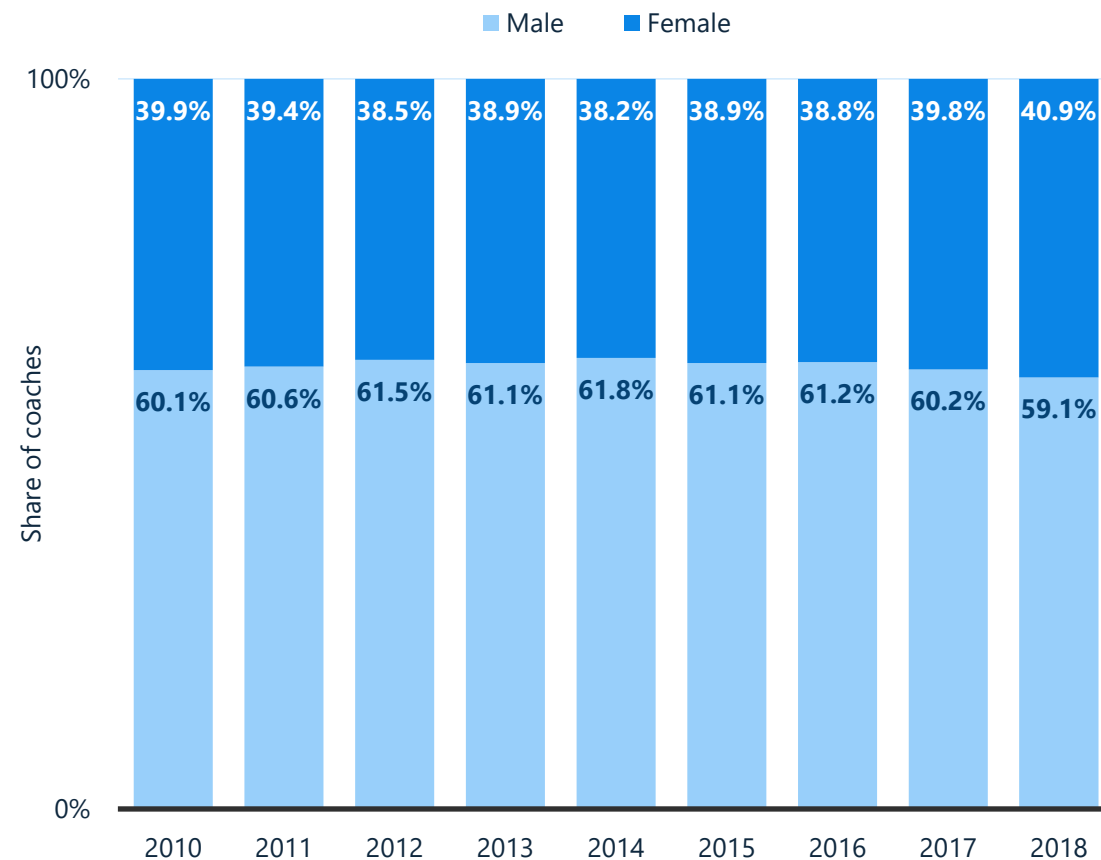
Combined athletics programs only need one director – usually a man

There is more female representation in the lower divisions, but male directors dominate Division I



Title IX may have helped women on the pitch, but they have suffered on the sidelines

Prior to 1972, women held the vast majority of coaching jobs for women's teams; over the last decade, they consistently held less than half

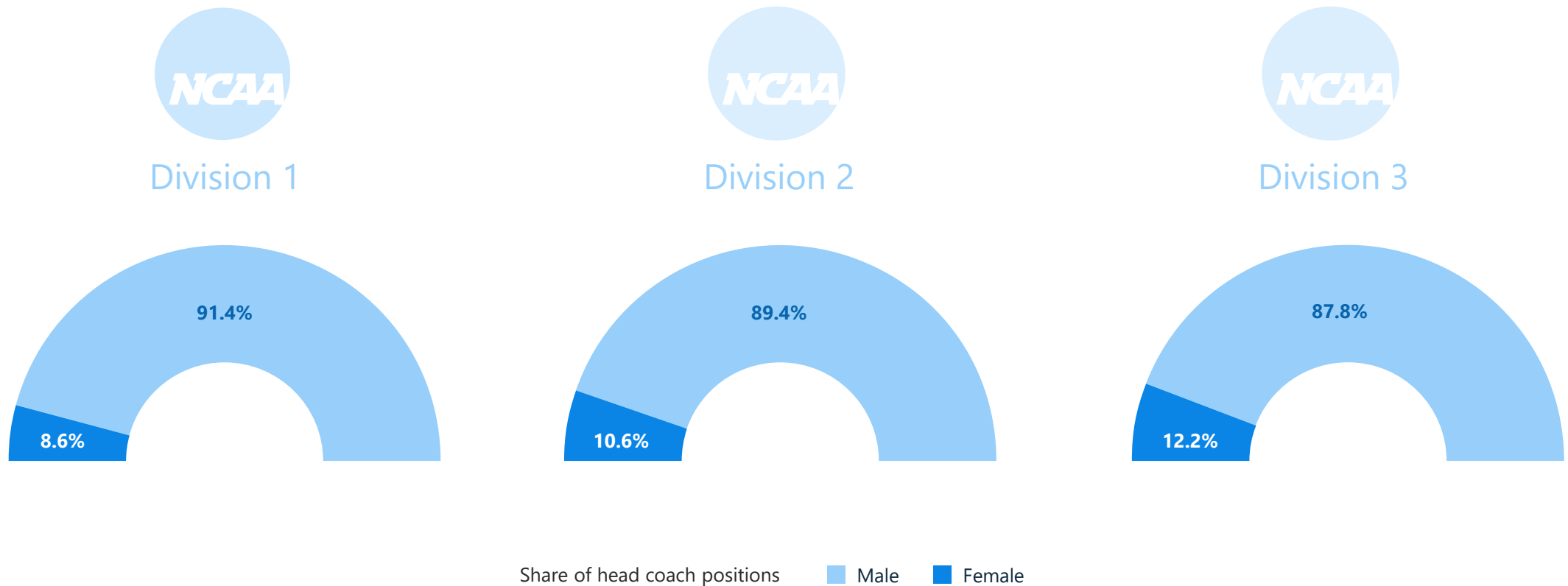


Following Title IX, male coaches recognized the appeal of coaching women's teams

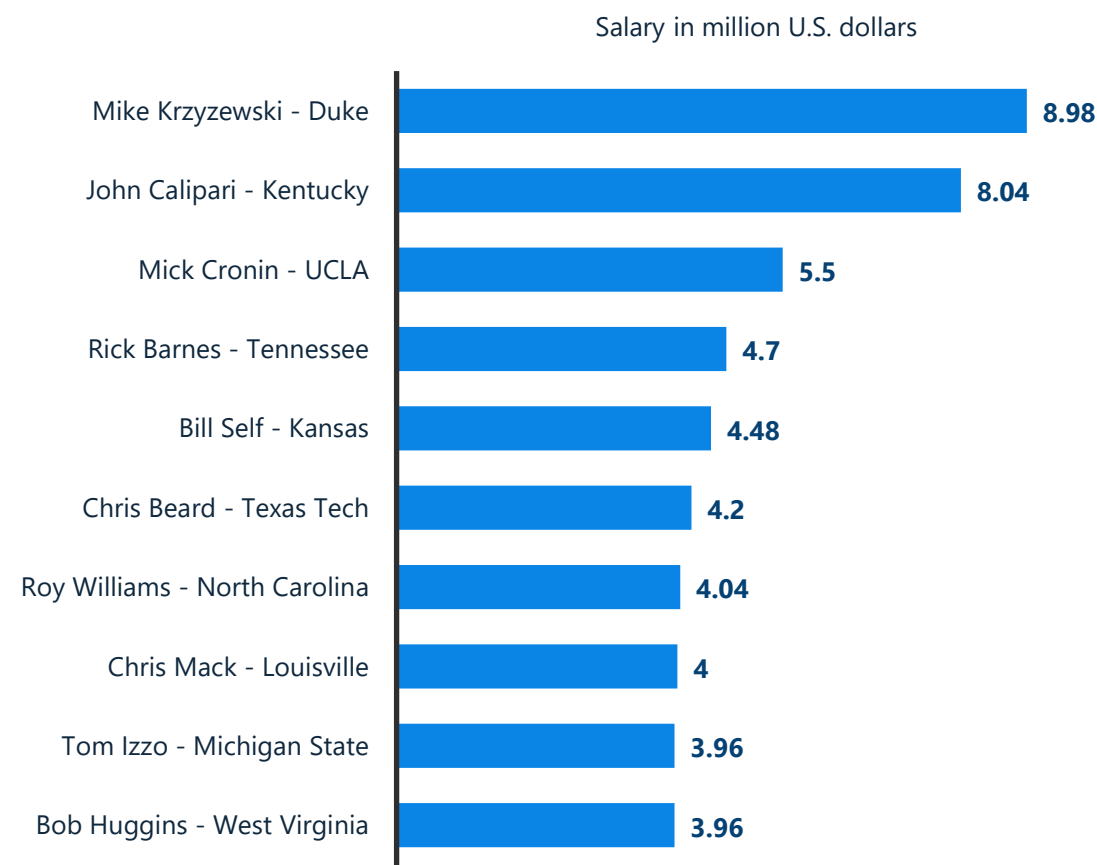
Prior to 1972, the majority of women's college teams were coached by women. For those who were seeking to climb up the career ladder, there was little appeal in women's teams that were underfunded and under-supported. This all changed with the equal opportunities brought about by Title IX: The money and support now afforded women's teams suddenly became an appealing prospect for ambitious coaches. As a result, the female coaches, who were fewer in number and often had less experience or opportunities available than their male counterparts, were pushed away from the sidelines. However, while men were taking on coaching positions for women's teams, the female coaches did not have the same opportunities to coach men's teams. An often-quoted explanation for this is that men's and women's sports are different and that male coaches, many of whom are former players themselves, understand the men's game better. This, however, does not explain why female coaches have been pushed out of the women's game since Title IX took effect.

Men's college teams are predominantly coached by men

Only a handful of women coach men's college teams, with no female head coaches of men's NCAA basketball



Male coaches dominate the college basketball earnings list



Coaching a men’s college basketball team earns the big bucks, but only male coaches are cashing in

There are over 350 NCAA Division I men’s basketball programs in the United States, employing over 1,400 full-time basketball coaches. The head coaches are in line to receive handsome compensation, with Duke’s Mike Krzyzewski, the first men’s Division 1 coach to reach 1,000 career wins, picking up almost nine million U.S. dollars in 2020. However, in this vast pool of Division I coaches, there is only one woman: Edniesha Curry, currently assistant at Maine Black Bears, following her two-year stint as assistant of the women’s team – her reported annual wage in 2018 was 47,705 U.S. dollars. To find the only female head coach in men’s college basketball, you have to drop down to Mesabi Range College in the National Junior College Athletic Association (NJCAA) and their new head coach, Tamara Moore. Moore had an impressive playing career, finishing as her college’s all-time leader in steals and assists and spending five years playing in the WNBA. Despite this impressive basketball experience and having coached men’s teams to championships before, her dream of becoming the first head coach of a Division I men’s program is yet to become a reality.



02 Professional sports pay gap

- Team sports
- Individual athletes
- Endorsements & sponsorship

The pay gap in professional sports

The gap is closing, but female athletes and teams are still behind

It is clear that money makes the sports world go around, and this is no more evident than in the top professional sports leagues. The league revenues of the National Football League (NFL), National Basketball Association (NBA), National Hockey League (NHL), and Major League Baseball (MLB) have all grown into the tens of billions of U.S. dollars in recent years, with lucrative media rights and sponsorship deals meaning that the expansion shows no signs of slowing down. But where do the top women's pro sports leagues fit into this equation?

The vast majority of women's leagues are still young in comparison to their male equivalents and have lacked the funding, sponsorship, and support to grow at a similar rate. With less money being generated and fewer fans watching in the stadiums and back home on TV, it is evident that the female athletes within these leagues are paid less for their endeavors. Salaries of the biggest stars in female team sports are usually a fraction of those playing the men's game, even those of male athletes playing to a comparatively lower standard. However, with federations and sponsors more likely to invest in the already profitable men's leagues to gain a quick return on investment rather than supporting fledgling women's leagues from the bottom up, can this gender gap in team sports change any time soon?

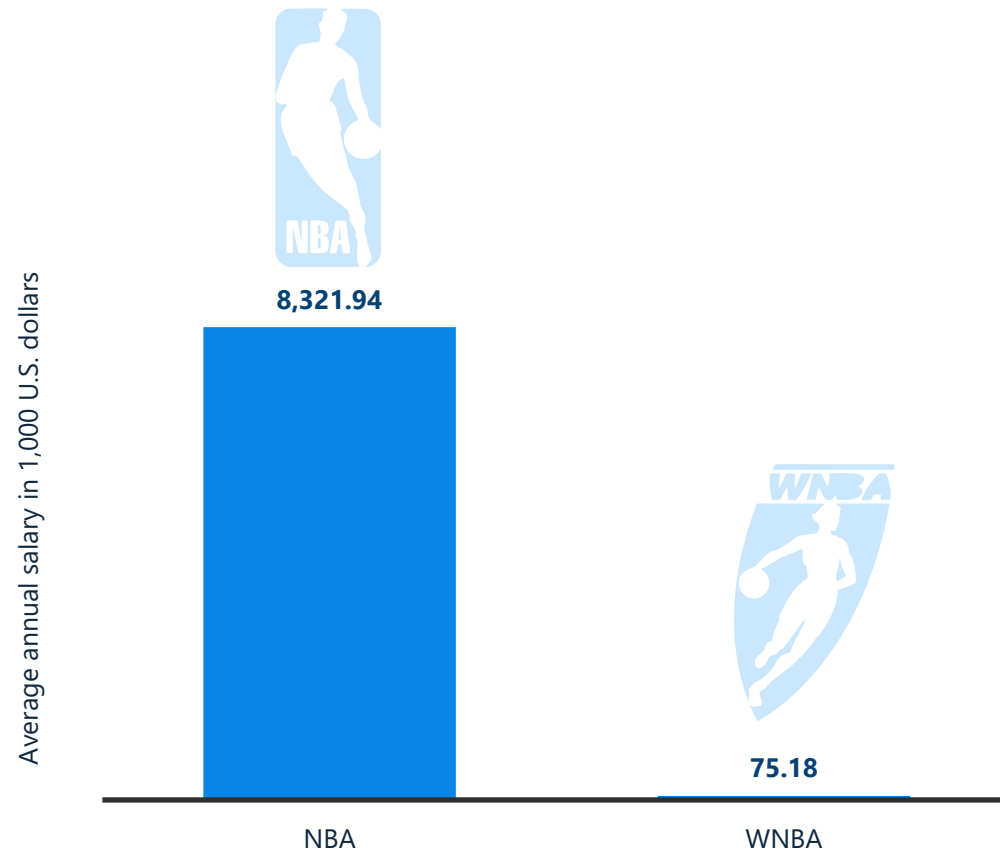
The pay gap situation in individual sports is quite complex and not easily summed up. Golf and tennis are just two examples of how gender inequality plays out both inside and outside the sporting arena:

While men's golf has certainly never hit the mainstream appeal of sports such as basketball and football, the money within the sport has still made multi-millionaires of its top stars. Meanwhile, women's golf does not reach as wide an audience and the proportional earnings available to the top female golfers are significantly lower. This is despite the fact that the top golfers of both genders display a similar level of skill in various metrics on the course.

One shining light in this discussion is tennis. Since 2007, all the sport's Grand Slam tournaments offer equal prize money to both genders, despite the argument that the men generally have to spend more time on court for their money (best of five sets instead of best of three sets). Tennis also stands out as the only sport where female athletes can compete with male athletes in terms of pay. In recent years, only female tennis stars, such as Serena Williams and Naomi Osaka, have managed to break into the top 100 list of highest paid sports stars worldwide.

WNBA average player salaries are just a fraction of the NBA

But with the NBA being one of the most lucrative leagues in the world, how understandable is this gulf?



The NBA may be bigger and older than the WNBA, but are the players worth over 100 times more?

The NBA is more than just a professional basketball league – it is an advertising gold mine and a dream for broadcasters. With fans flocking in their thousands to the stadiums and millions more watching at home, it is no wonder that the league generated revenue upward of eight billion U.S. dollars in recent years. The main attraction of the NBA is, of course, its players, so it is unsurprising that the current crop of superstars, including LeBron James and Steph Curry, command a handsome fee for their services.

In comparison, the WNBA is still in the early stages of development, having only been founded in 1997. The league has nevertheless experienced significant growth since then, with latest figures putting WNBA league revenue at an estimated 60 million U.S. dollars. Given that this is just a small fraction of the revenue generated by the NBA, estimated at 7.4 billion U.S. dollars, it comes as no surprise that the players of WNBA take home less money in their annual paychecks. But there is more to this pay gap, as will be shown on the next pages.

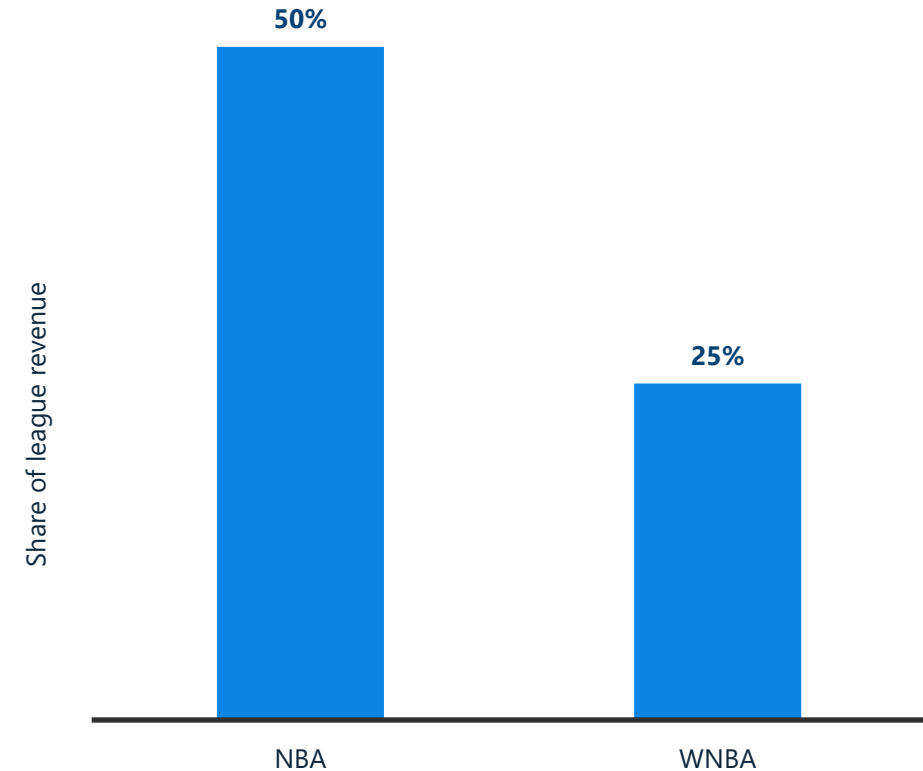
WNBA players are getting a smaller slice of the league revenue pie

Even when the smaller revenues are taken into account, WNBA stars appear to be missing out

While the NBA invests approximately half of its total revenue back into its product – the players –, the stars of the WNBA are estimated to receive about a quarter of the league's revenue.

Just as in the NBA, a huge part of the WNBA's growing appeal is its star players – fan favorites, such as Elena Delle Donne, Diana Taurasi, and Sue Bird, contribute greatly to the league's appeal, whether it be through gate receipts, broadcasting deals, merchandise sales, or social media followers. Fans ultimately come to see the team and the players. Questions could therefore be raised about why, on a proportional level, there is a significant gender pay gap in North America's top professional basketball leagues.

It therefore remains to be seen whether, as the WNBA grows in revenue, more of this profit is invested back into the players themselves, as has been seen in the recent growth in male professional sport.



” *In order to make money, you have to spend money. When the NBA began, its seats were not filled. It was not driving millions of viewers. The difference is more money was spent to build that league.* “

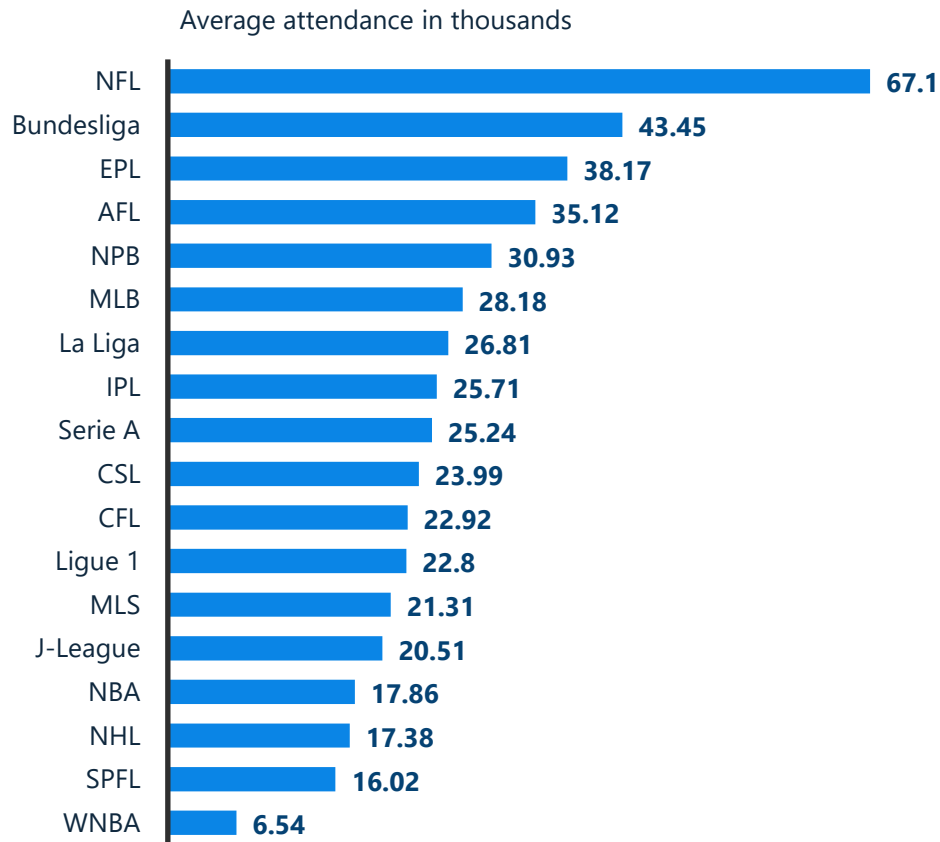
—

Alicia Jessop

Pepperdine University
sport law professor

Women's league attendances still have some catching up to do

Until women's sports leagues can reach a wider audience in the stadiums and back home, increasing wages may be difficult

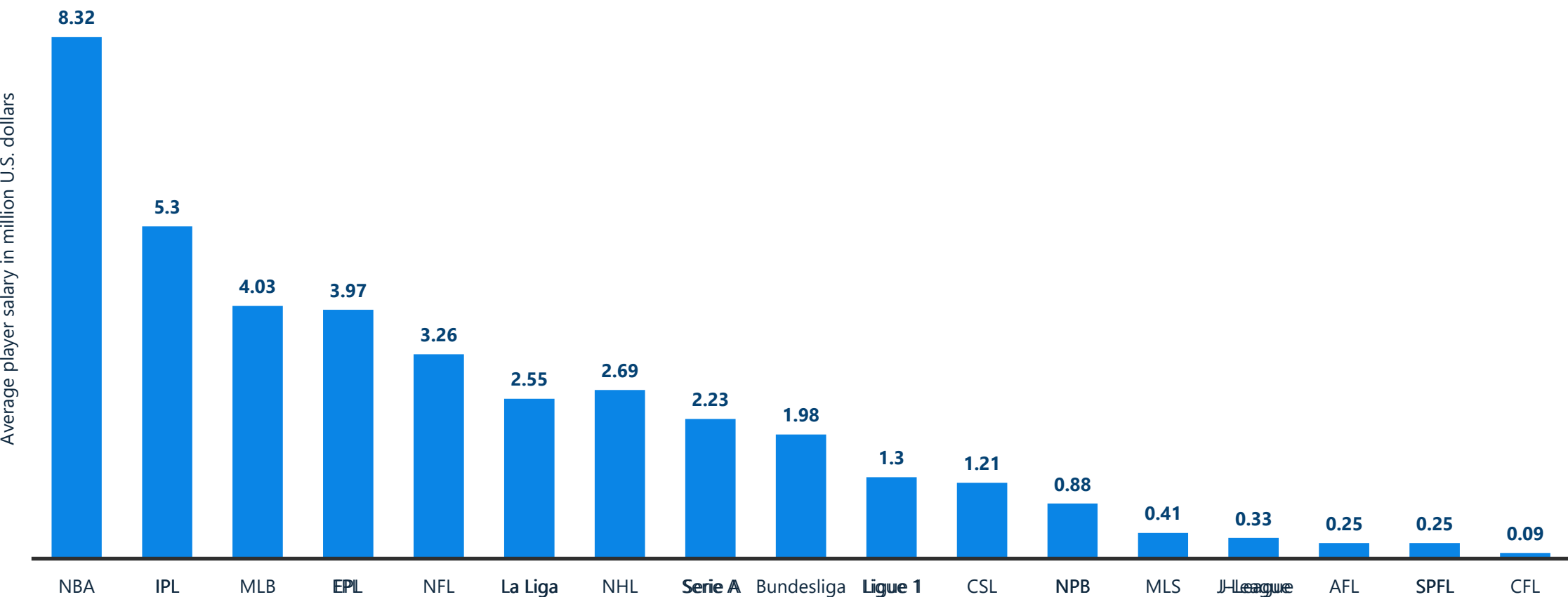


The NFL was founded in 1920. The NBA emerged just after the Second World War in 1946. The German Bundesliga celebrated its inaugural season in 1963. And Major League Baseball was founded all the way back in 1903. In comparison, leagues such as the WNBA and the FA Women's Super League, the highest league of women's soccer in England, are mere infants, having been founded in 1996 and 2011, respectively. With less time to develop a fan base and a worldwide presence, as well as significantly less funding than the equivalent male leagues, it is no surprise that women's leagues are still lagging behind in terms of revenue and attendance.

However, this does not mean that the potential is not there. During the WNBA's 23rd season in 2019, teams averaged 6,535 fans per game. While this figure is not in itself too impressive, it is worth noting that in the NBA's 23rd season in 1968-69, average attendances stood at 6,484. These figures suggest that, given the right investment and marketing, the potential is there for women's leagues to become a financial success just like their male counterparts. This is especially true in today's online society, where marketing a product across the world has become significantly easier than it was in the early stages of the 20th century.

Men's leagues across the world pay their stars handsomely

Millions of U.S. dollars of revenue through TV deals, gate receipts, and marketing leaves a big pot of money for the players



With less revenue and investment, women's leagues can't afford to reward their stars

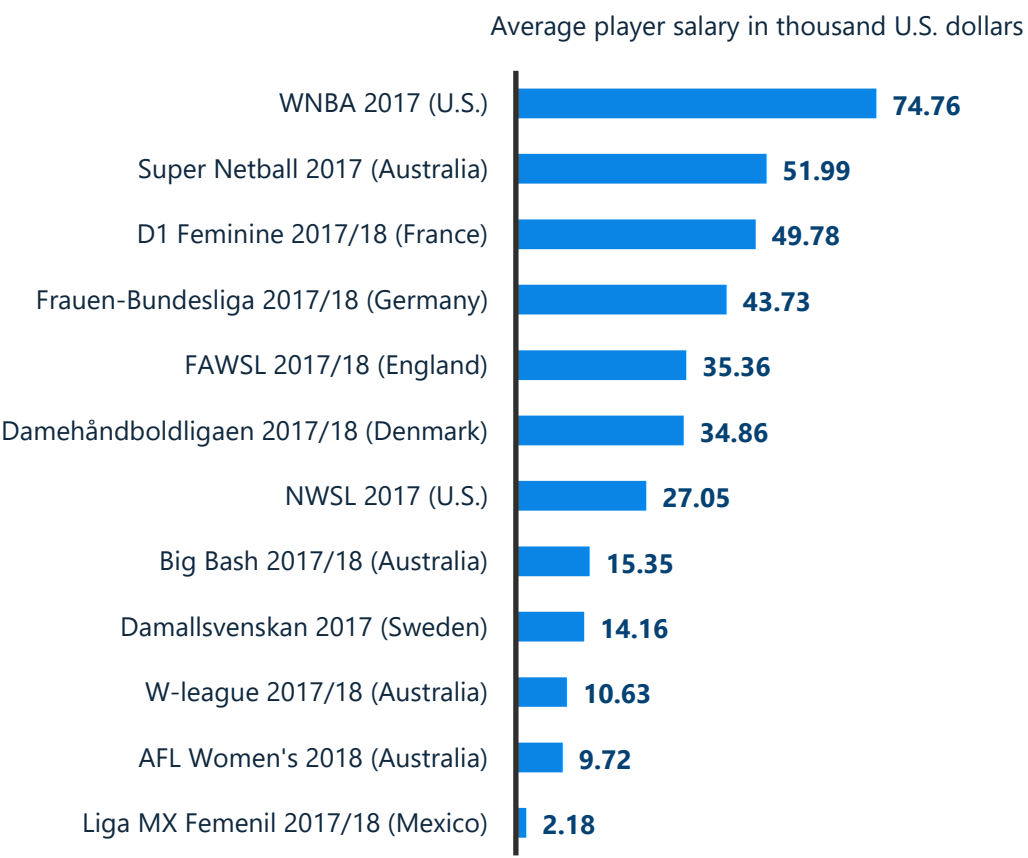
As the most lucrative women's league worldwide, the WNBA leads the way in paying its players

Even newer competitions pay female players less

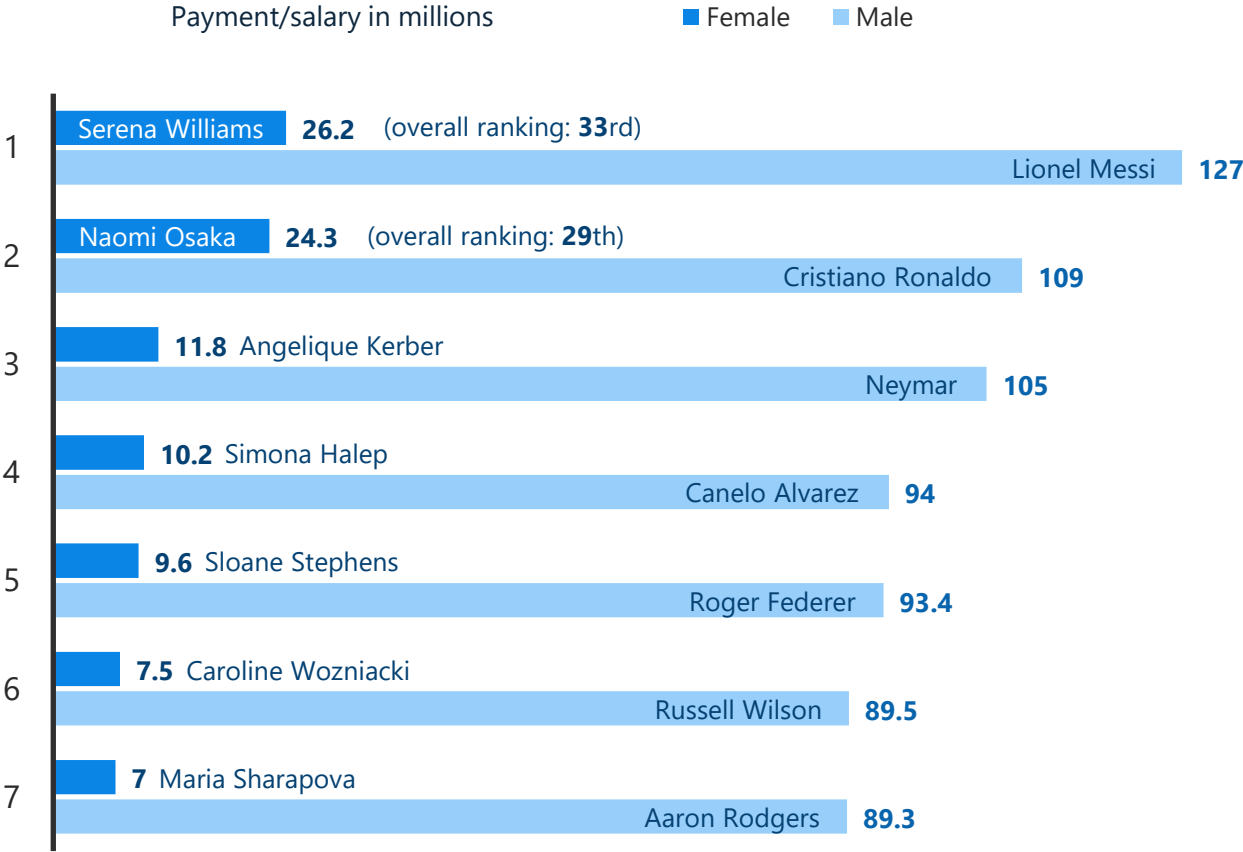
While the WNBA has 23 seasons under its belt, some of the younger women's global sports leagues have not established themselves enough on the worldwide stage to be able to pay their stars top dollar.

In the Australian Big Bash League (BBL), for example, one of the world's top domestic cricket competitions, the salary cap for male players stood at 1.6 million U.S. dollars for the latest season. While the salary cap has gone up in recent years to match the tournament's success, the top stars were still able to bank up to one million U.S. dollars for their exploits in the competition's inaugural season in 2011-12.

By comparison, female cricketers during the same first year of the Women's Big Bash League (WBBL) earned between 3,000 and 10,000 U.S. dollars. While these salaries were no doubt calculated on the expected revenues of the respective tournaments, the huge gulf in salaries for even brand-new competitions nevertheless suggests that less investment and sponsorship is pumped into women's sport, thereby limiting the amount that can be spent on the individual athletes.



While some female athletes stand shoulder to shoulder with men on the court, the outlook off the court is vastly different



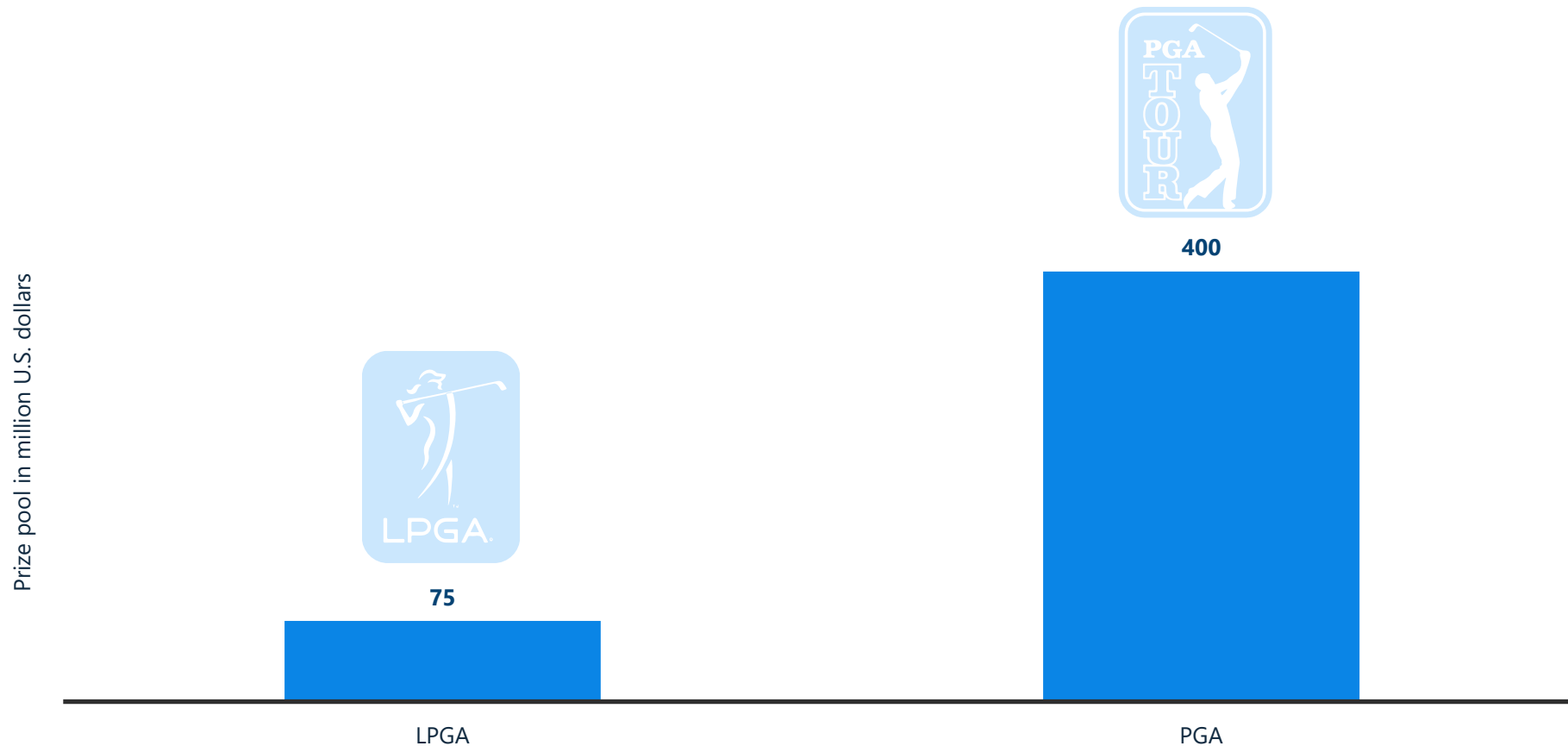
Top male team sports players command lucrative contracts and sponsorship deals, while only 2 female athletes make the cut

When analyzing the list of the highest paid athletes worldwide, one thing becomes clear: male athletes are able to earn millions of U.S. dollars for their talents. The top ten list includes stars from the world of tennis, soccer, basketball, golf, and football. It seems that, across the board, the top stars of any sport reap the financial rewards.

However, scrolling down the list makes one thing conspicuous in its absence – the female athletes. Indeed, the first woman who appears on the list is Naomi Osaka in 29th place. The only other woman on the list is fellow tennis star, Serena Williams, who has held down the fort as the only woman on the list for the last several years, in 33rd place. No female players of any team sports make the top 100, while 72 male team sports stars make the cut, along with 26 male athletes competing in individual sports.

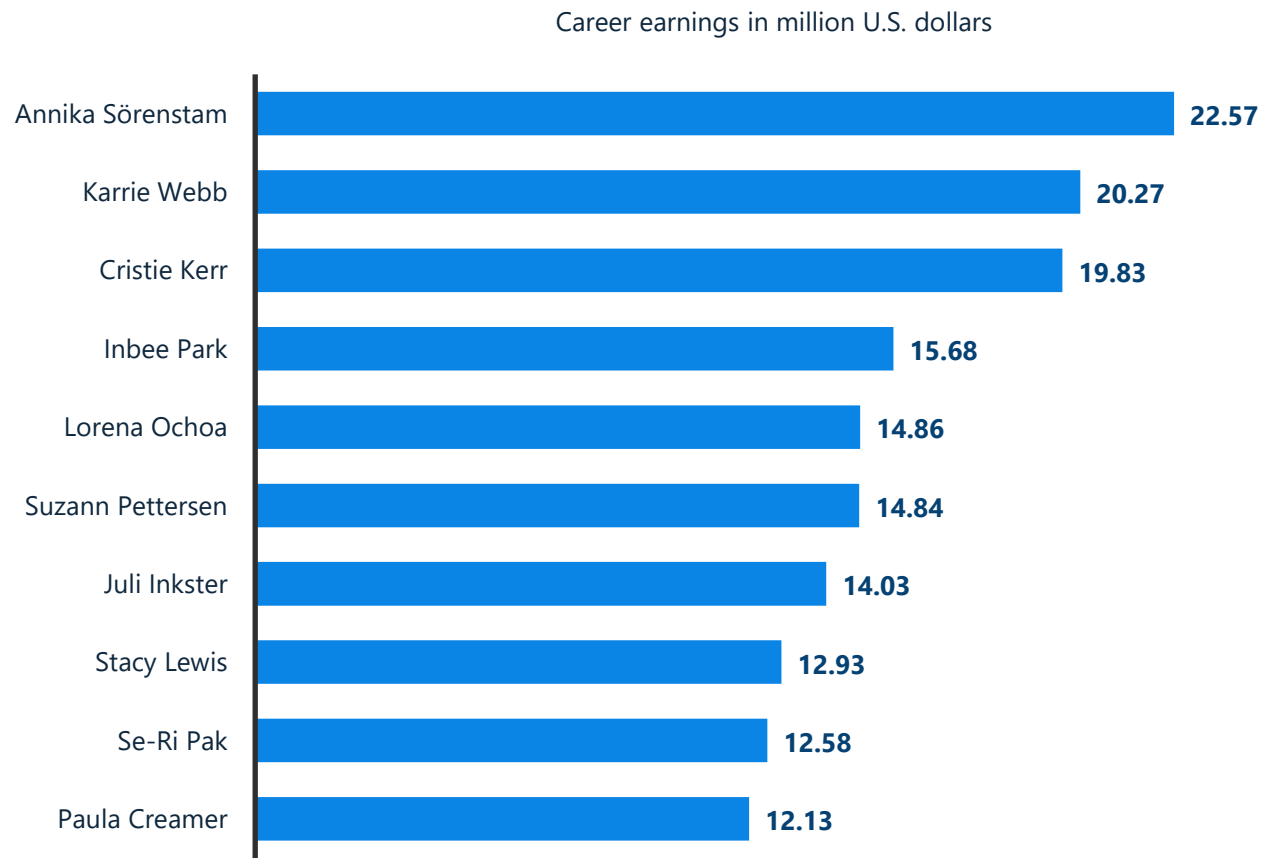
On the golf course, male pros play for a mammoth prize pot

While the prize pool for the 33 events on the women's professional tour (LPGA) is at a record high, it has not yet reached a fifth of the men's (PGA) tournament fund



Top female golfers can now earn millions in their career

But these millions still fall short in contrast to the earnings of the top male golfers

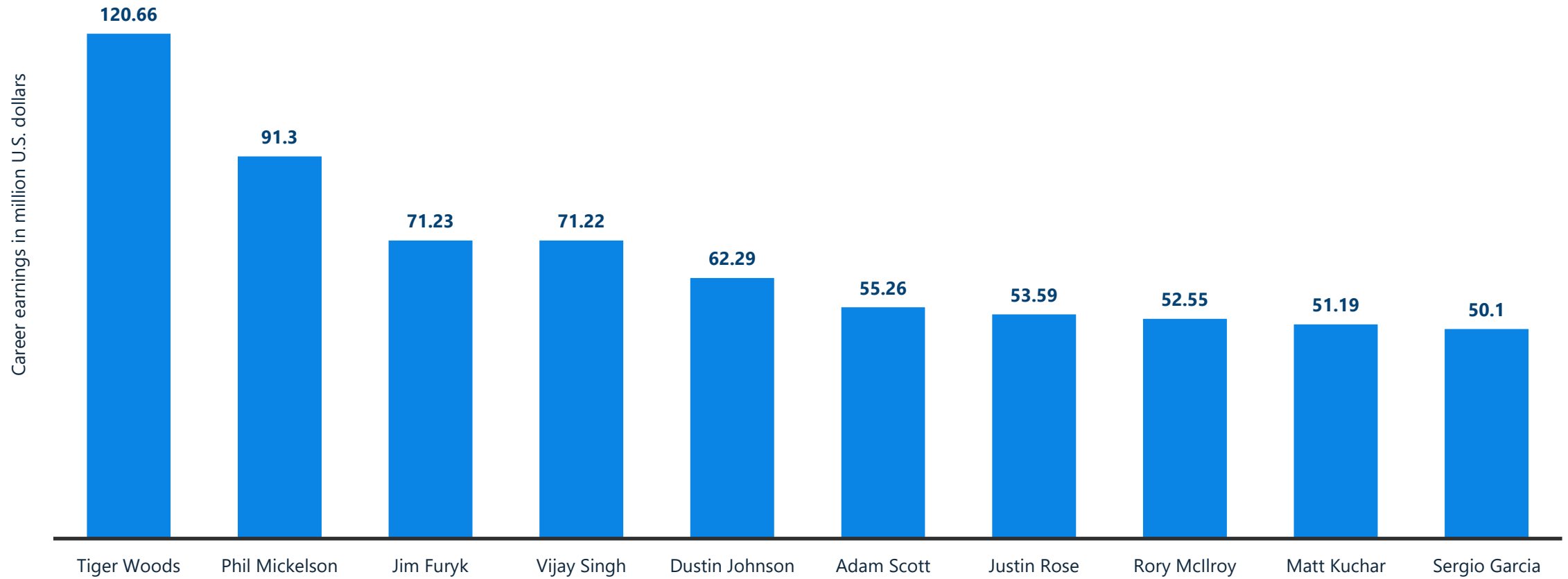


Annika Sörenstam leads the LPGA money list

While the Swedish golfer's earnings would make her objectively wealthy by any measure, her 22.57 million U.S. dollars' worth of prize money would put her around 68th on the men's all-time list. This would place Sörenstam just ahead of Aaron Baddeley, who so far has four PGA Tour victories to his name. By contrast, Sörenstam recorded 72 career victories on the LPGA Tour, including ten majors, making her the female golfer with the most wins under her belt.

The men's list is led by American golfer, Tiger Woods. His 82 PGA Tour victories alongside his 15 major wins have earned him an impressive 120 million U.S. dollars across his career (see next page). While both Sörenstam and Woods are rightly considered legends of the game with a slew of titles to their names, the difference in their accumulated wealth of almost 100 million U.S. dollars is remarkable.

The top ten male golfers have all earned over 50 million U.S. dollars, with Tiger Woods even reaching triple figures



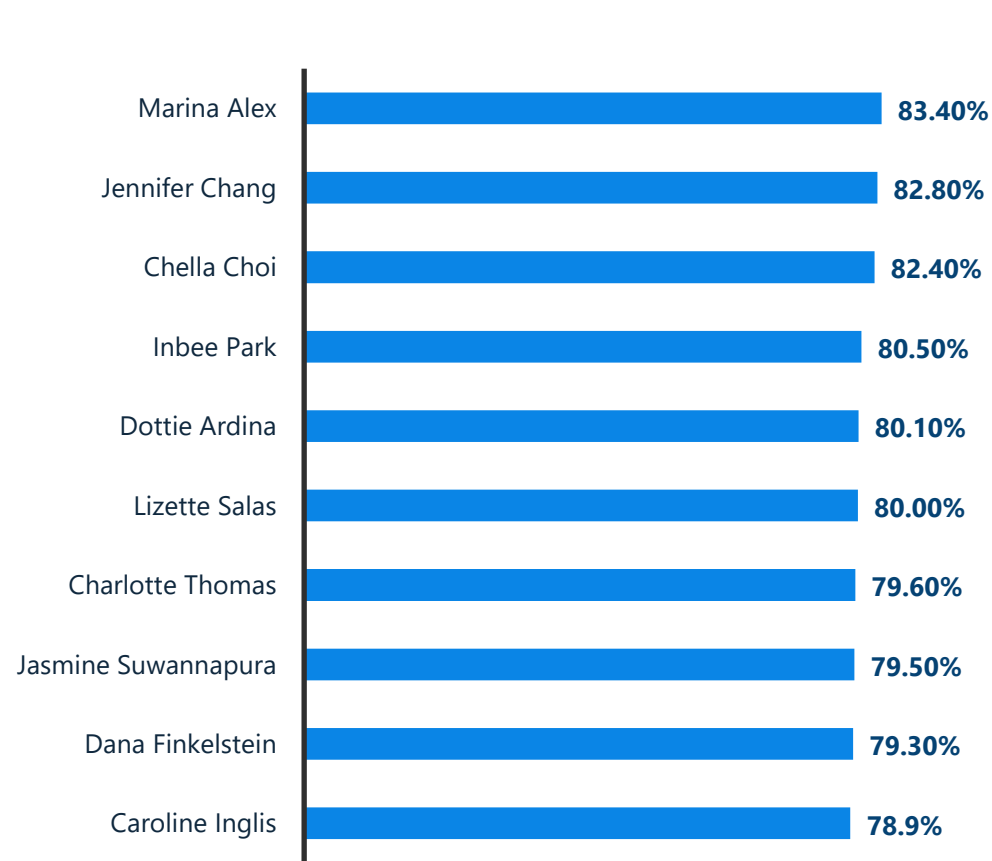
When it comes to skill on the course, male and female golfers are neck and neck

Male golfers hit the ball further, but female golfers hit the fairways more often

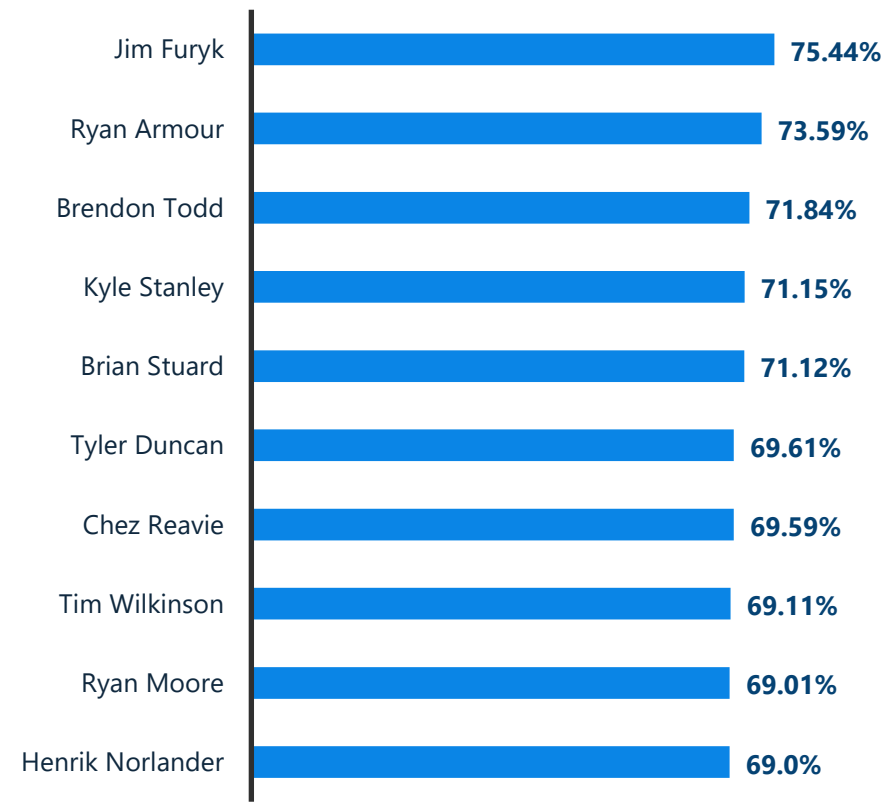
One of the frequently-used arguments to explain the gender pay gap in professional sport is that male athletes must display a higher level of skill than females in their respective disciplines. It is interesting to compare the skill levels demonstrated by the two genders on the golf course, especially given that the battle is often as much against the course itself than against fellow golfers: Due to their (on average) bigger build, male golfers are generally able to hit the ball further. However, in other barometers of skill in golf – such as greens in regulation (GIR), driving accuracy, average score, and putting average – male and female golfers are closely matched, with the women even coming out on top in several categories, as can be seen on the next slide. Given that the level of skill displayed by both genders is ostensibly similar, the pay gap cannot be sufficiently explained by this.

While public interest in women's golf is apparent based on the viewing figures of major tournaments, it is still some way behind the men's events – coverage of the final round of the men's British Open in 2019 drew in 3.7 million viewers in the United States, while around 1.2 million viewers tuned into the women's event, making it the most-watched final round of the event in 13 years. The women's event thus attracted a third of the viewers of the men's event, but the difference in prize money is even higher still. Given the upturn in viewers of women's golf and the broad appeal of the international competition (the previous 16 women's majors have had 13 different winners from seven countries), it seems there is some argument for beginning to close the gender pay gap seen in golf.

Female professional golfers eclipsed their male counterparts in driving accuracy on their respective tours in 2020

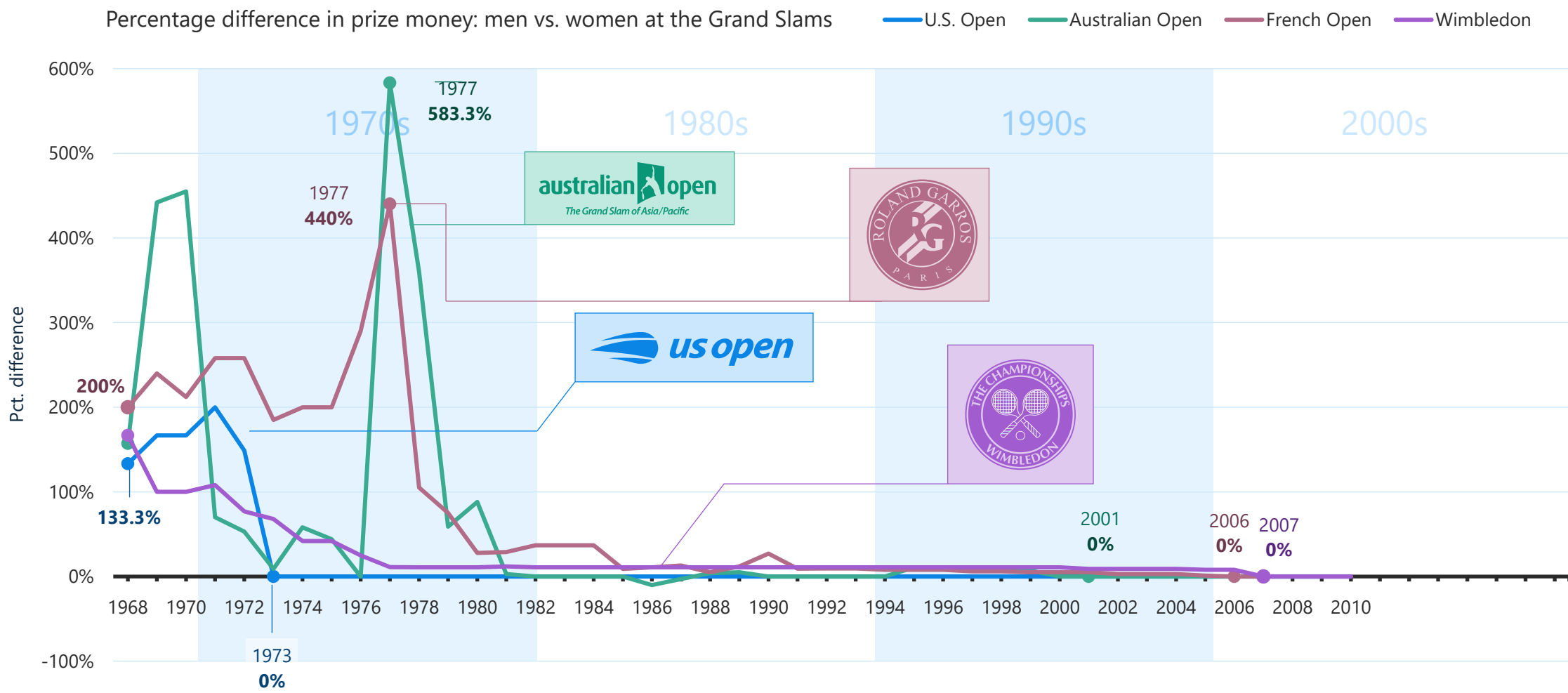


Note: Worldwide; 2020 season
Source(s): LPGA; [ID 1121445](#)



Note: Worldwide; 2020 season
Source(s): PGA; [ID 811034](#)

Tennis has fought a long battle for equal pay, starting with the U.S. Open in 1973



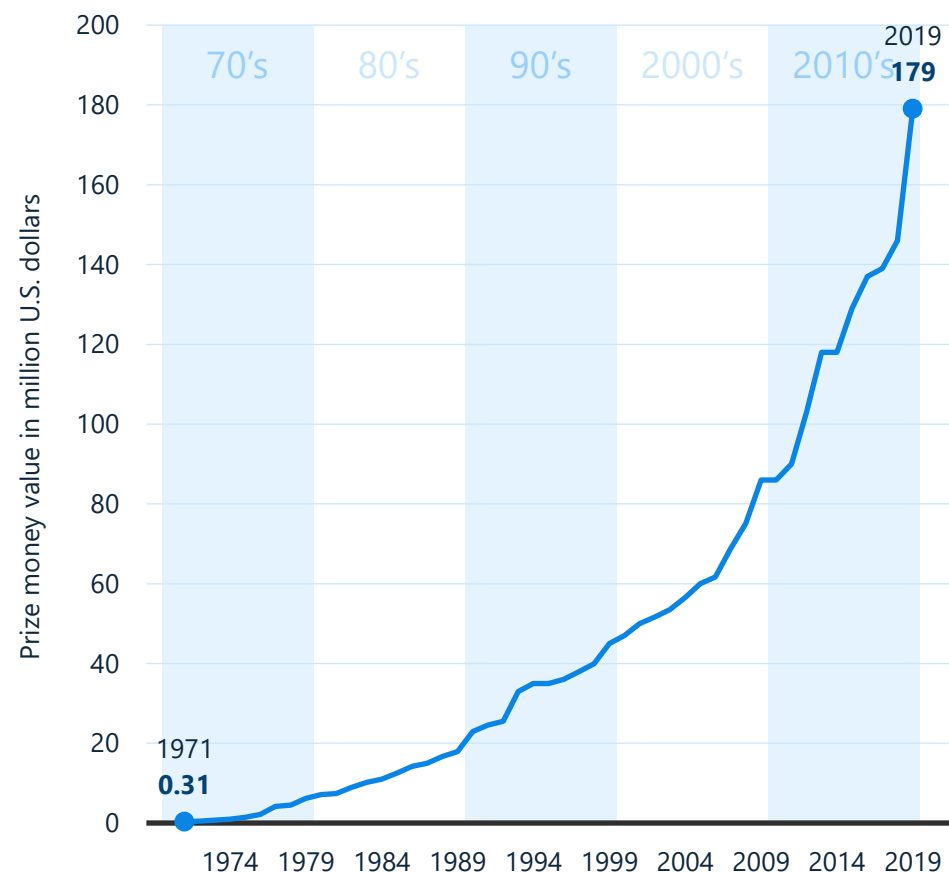
Tournament prize money for the Women's Tennis Association (WTA) has consistently been on the up

Tennis leads the way for gender equality on the court, will more sports follow?

Pioneering tennis players led the charge for equal pay on the court

In 1973, the world's best and most recognizable female tennis player, Billie Jean King, threatened to boycott the U.S. Open if steps were not made to address pay inequality within the sport. Her protest was a success, and the U.S. Open became the first major tennis tournament to provide equal prize money for the men's and women's tournaments. The Australian Open and the French Open followed suit in 2001 and 2006 respectively, but it was not until a vocal protest by a number of female players, including Venus Williams, that Wimbledon offered equal prize money in 2007.

Since Billie Jean King's landmark stand in 1973, tournament prize money for WTA events has been steadily on the rise, reaching a high of 179 million U.S. dollars in 2019. The WTA Finals event in 2019 was held in Shenzhen, China, the first year of its ten-year run in the country. With the backing of Shiseido, a Japanese cosmetics company, as the main sponsor, the event had a record prize money pot of 14 million U.S. dollars. Australia's Ashleigh Barty won the singles event and bagged the big prize of 4.42 million U.S. dollars, the largest single prize win in professional tennis history. These staggering numbers show how, with targeted marketing and the backing of big sponsors, the money offered to top female athletes can reach parity and, on this occasion, even exceed men's sport.



”

There was a true commitment here, trying to do something about 'walking the walk' when it comes to women's empowerment. It made a huge impression on us when we saw someone who didn't just talk the talk.

“

—

Steve Simon

WTA's CEO

Despite tennis making significant strides forward, players still work for two different federations

Pay is equal, but players remain divided

Tennis is definitely heading in the direction of gender equality – this is evident in the prize money the female players command and the fact that the biggest four tournaments of the year in terms of audience and profit, the Grand Slams, are played as combined gender tournaments.

This success for female tennis players points towards the next logical step: combining tennis' two federations – the ATP for the men and the WTA for the women. This would naturally lead to a merging of marketing power, potential audience, social media presence, and much more, creating a cohesive federation for a sport that has already worked significantly towards gender equality. This step is clearly one that is hotly debated, not only in the media but also within the sport itself, with one of the most successful male players of all time, Roger Federer, often voicing his opinion.

However, the reality is that the male and female tours still remain separate, despite the same sport being played on court. The fact that there has been a gradual increase in the number of male-only tournaments popping up on the calendar in recent years suggests that tennis still has room to grow together as one united sport.



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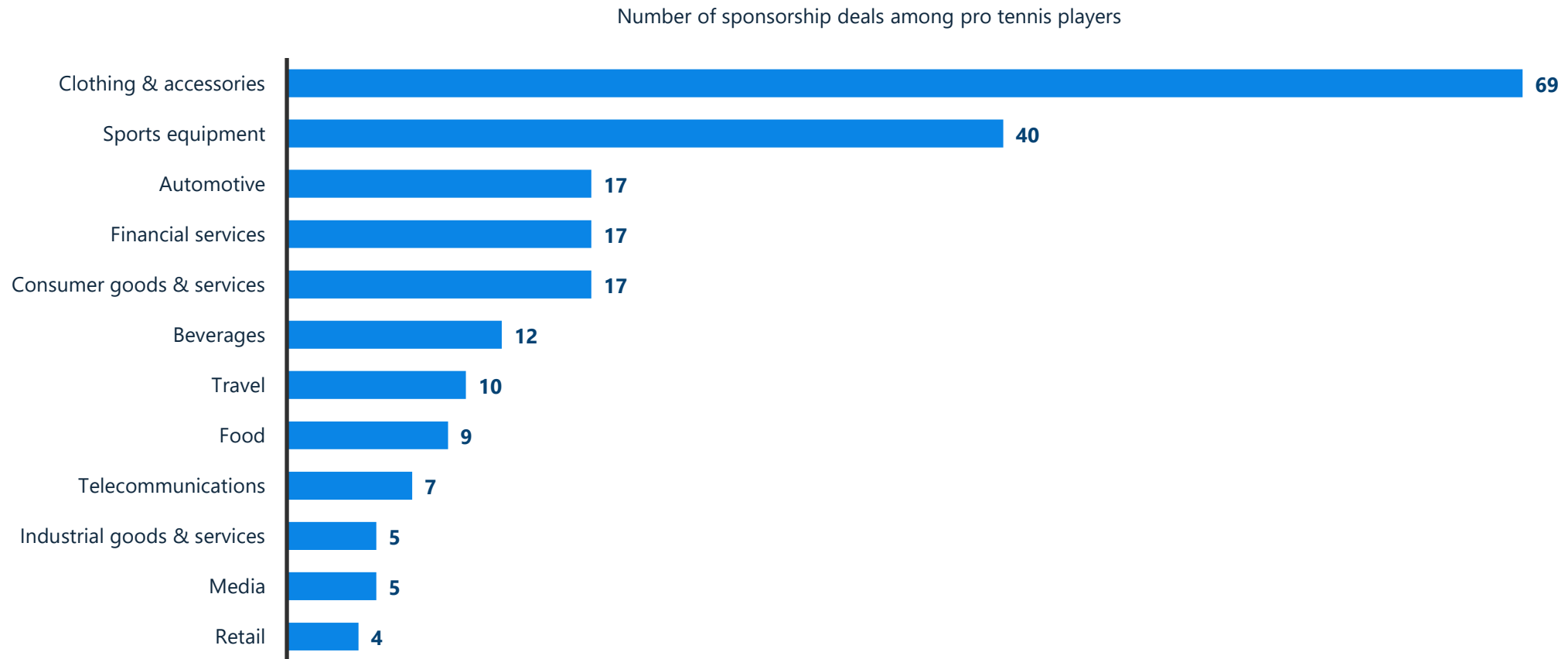
*Just wondering.....
am I the only one thinking that
now is the time for men's and
women's tennis to be united and
come together as one?*

“

Roger Federer,
April 22, 2020

As some of the most recognizable athletes in the world, tennis stars cash in with lucrative sponsorship deals

Players lend their name to a variety of products – from the clothes they wear to the cars they drive



Popular brands cash in on two of the most famous faces in tennis

Despite both having numerous brands in their sponsorship portfolio, Federer's sponsorship value is much higher

Serena Williams



Total sponsorship worth: **25m U.S. dollars**

Roger Federer



Total sponsorship worth: **86m U.S. dollars**

Tennis players are equal on the court, but male players command more lucrative sponsorship deals

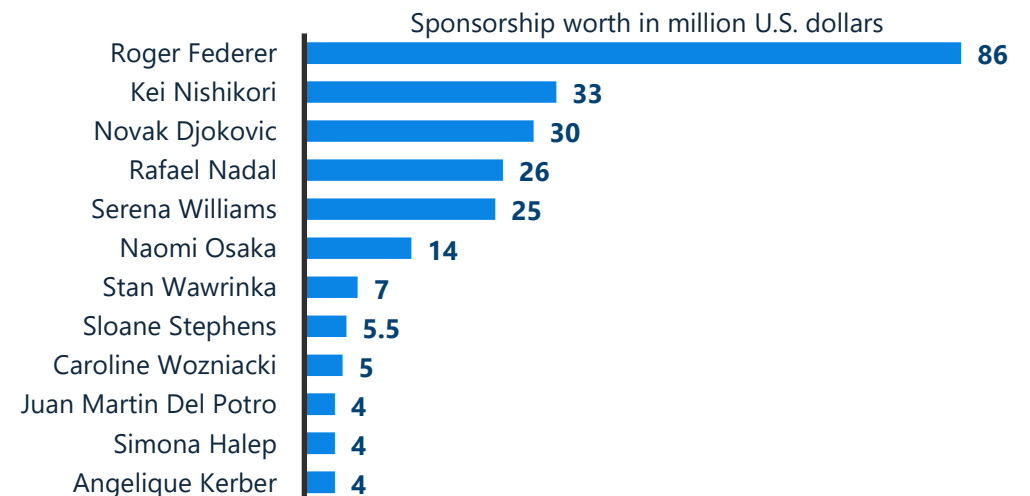
Roger Federer has built up a sponsorship empire; Serena Williams earns less than a third

Why are female tennis stars seen as less marketable than their male counterparts?

Roger Federer is one of the most successful male tennis players of all time, so it is unsurprising that brands flock to him to promote their latest products. Equally, Serena Williams will go down in history as one of the greatest female tennis players ever, with a record 23 Grand Slam titles to her name. While Federer and Williams now get paid equally for every Grand Slam victory, there is still a significant gulf off the court: Williams has an army of loyal followers and is seen as a female sporting icon, yet her sponsorship worth of 25 million U.S. dollars pales in comparison to Federer's 86 million U.S. dollars. In fact, despite being one of the most recognizable faces in the sport, Williams is also behind three other male players in the rankings.

Interestingly, female tennis players average a higher number of sponsorship deals than male players, but this does not seem to directly translate to income. In today's online world, it is vitally important for brands that athletes can reach a wide audience. While Rafael Nadal and Roger Federer have both amassed over 33 million social media followers across the globe, it is Serena Williams that sits in third place with over 27 million followers.

This online presence is over ten times as large as that of Kei Nishikori, yet the Japanese star's sponsorship worth is significantly higher than Williams'. Given the marketability and appeal of rising female tennis stars, such as Naomi Osaka and Angelique Kerber, and the fact that some of male tennis' big names, such as Federer and Djokovic, are coming to the end of their long careers, now may be the time for brands to make the most of the growth of women's tennis.





03 Case study: U.S. Women's National Soccer team

- National team successes
- The fight for equal pay
- The World Cup

U.S. soccer – a federation at war

A national team has taken its own federation to court – how did it come to this?

Since playing its first match in 1981, the incredible success of the United States women's national soccer team (USWNT) has propelled women's soccer to the mainstream consciousness in the United States. Soccer is one of the most popular sports among young girls and female college students and the top stars of the game, such as Alex Morgan and Megan Rapinoe, have become household names. Conversely, men's soccer has always struggled to find its space amongst America's other dominant male sports. Although the domestic league, Major League Soccer (MLS), has increased in popularity in recent years, the success of the men's national team (USMNT) on the international stage has been very limited. While the women's team are currently ranked first in the world and have a record four World Cup titles to their name, the men's team has never won a World Cup and currently sits at rank 23 in FIFA's world rankings.

However, despite this gulf in success on the pitch, off the pitch the men's team were consistently rewarded with higher salaries and bonuses. In 2016, members of the women's team took a stand: Five players from the USWNT – Alex Morgan, Hope Solo, Carli Lloyd, Megan Rapinoe, and Becky Sauerbrunn – filed a charge of wage discrimination against their employer, the United States Soccer Federation (USSF). This lawsuit has since been supported by 28 members of the U.S. women's national soccer team. In their lawsuit, the players submitted evidence of the men's national team receiving bonuses for losing friendly matches, while the women's team did

not receive such compensation for a loss or a draw. The win bonus was also significantly higher for the men, who also received more money for making the last 16 of the World Cup than the women did for placing second.

In 2017, the players signed a new collective bargaining agreement to secure better compensation, although they still did not reach the same level of reimbursement as the men. This led to an escalation of the dispute in March 2019, when the players filed a federal lawsuit against U.S. Soccer on the grounds of "institutional gender discrimination". In response, the federation submitted a defense stating that the national teams "receive fundamentally different pay structures for performing different work under their separate collective bargaining agreements that require different obligations and responsibilities" – this was interpreted as an implication that male players require a higher level of skill, speed, and strength. This response only served to heighten public discourse, with the female players suggesting that these arguments presented by U.S. Soccer illustrated the very gender discrimination that they were fighting against.

And the fight is not over: In May 2020, the players' claims were thrown out, but a trial regarding their complaints about unfair treatment in areas such as travel and medical was allowed. This dispute has now become very public, and the trial is set to continue in 2020.

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The U.S. women's soccer team does not need to be the best in the world in order to earn equal pay. The point of non-discrimination law is that employees doing similar work should be paid equally.

“

—

Suzanne B. Goldberg

director of the Center for Gender & Sexuality Law
at the Columbia Law School

A tale of two national teams ...

The U.S. women's team has dominated while the men's team has faltered



Current FIFA ranking: **1st**
Won a medal in **each** World Cup so far

Women



1985
played its first
ever match

1991
won the
World Cup

1996
won Olympic
gold

1999
won the
World Cup

2004
won Olympic
gold

2008
won Olympic
gold

2012
won Olympic
gold

2015
won the
World Cup

2019
won the
World Cup

1990

2000

2010

2020

Men



1916
played its first
ever match

1990
group stage
of World Cup

1994
round of 16 of
World Cup

1998
group stage
of World Cup

1954-1986
(9 successive tournaments) –
did not qualify for World Cup

2002
quarter finals of
World Cup

2006
group stage
of World Cup

2010
round of 16 of
World Cup

2014
round of 16 of
World Cup

2018
did not qualify

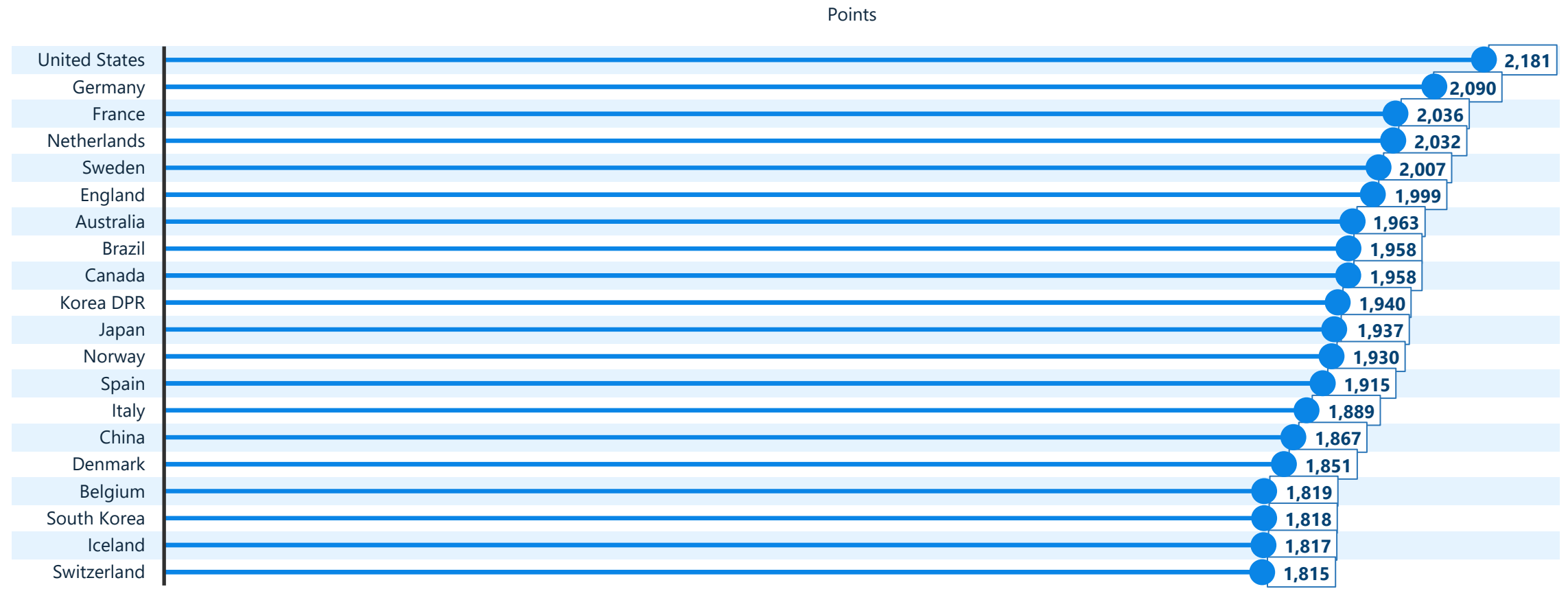


Current FIFA ranking: **23rd**
Best finish in Olympics **joint 5th** in 1956*

*excluding 1904 when only three teams competed, two of whom represented the U.S.

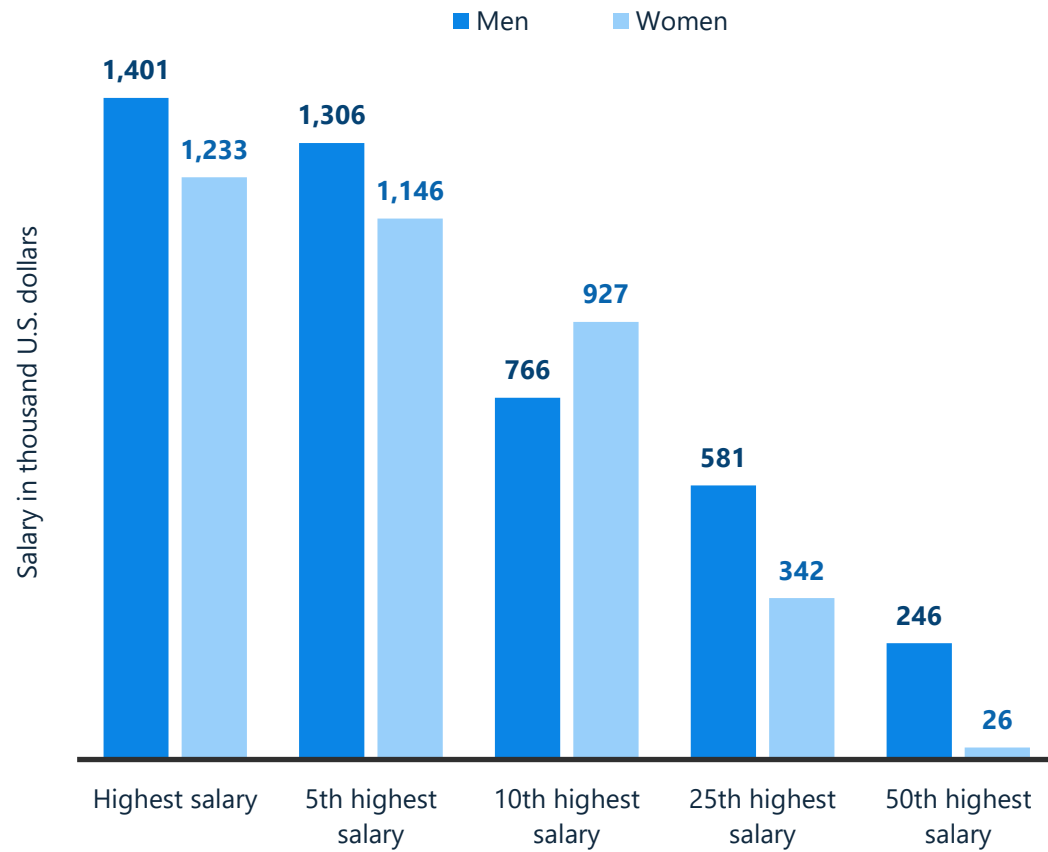
The USWNT is on top of the world, and has been for some time

FIFA world ranking of national women's soccer teams in 2020



Wages for the USMNT are higher almost across the board

The pay gap becomes even larger for the lower-paid squad players



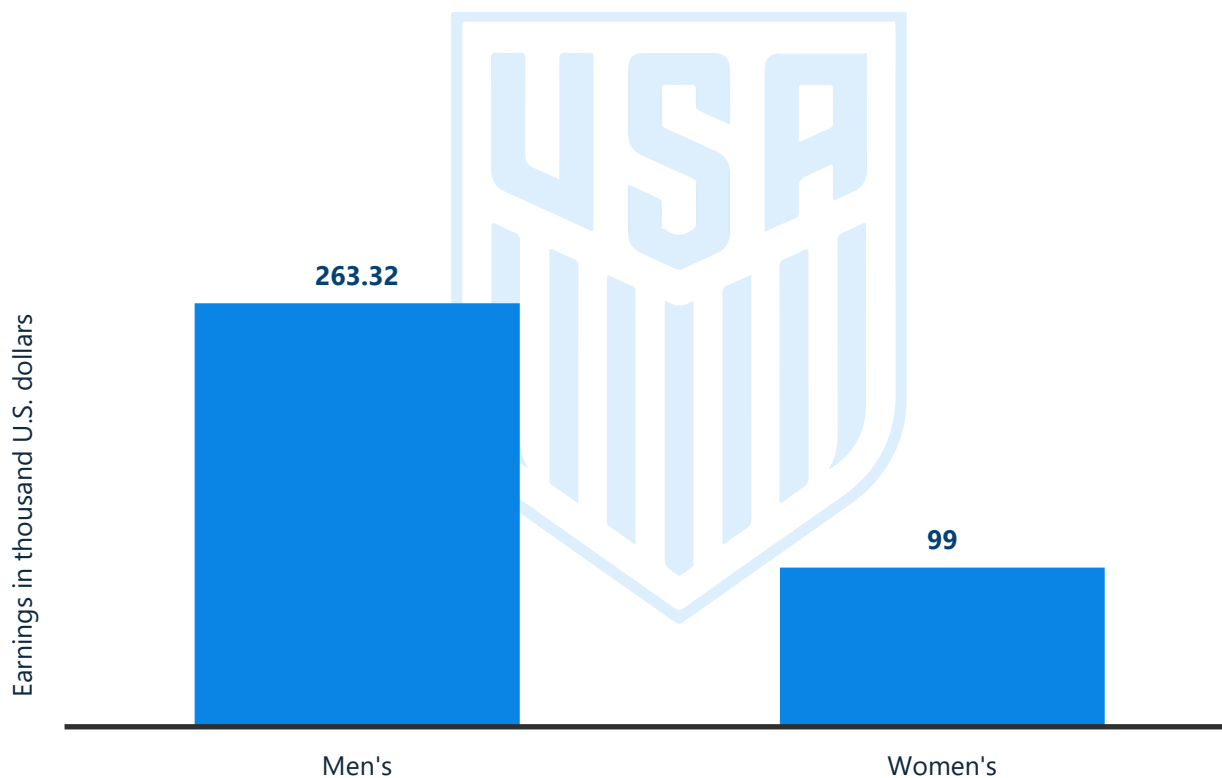
This pay gap was the foundation of the USWNT's lawsuit

While the top female stars of the USWNT are in line to receive over one million U.S. dollars for their exploits, this is still significantly lower than the salary of the highest paid members of the men's team. The pay gap gets even larger lower down the list, with the 50th highest salary for the men's team almost 10 times the equivalent salary on the women's team.

Before the inclusion of win bonuses and tournament fees, the men's national team's base salary is also higher than that of its female colleagues. One of the foundations of the lawsuit is that male and female employees of the same federation are being paid different amounts for essentially the same job – in this instance, representing their country at the highest level on a soccer field. The lawsuit points to the fundamental principle of anti-discrimination law, which is to protect those who are discriminated against on the grounds of gender, race or ethnic background, religion or belief, disability, age, or sexual orientation. Much like the arguments surrounding Title IX at college level, the women's inferior pay to the men's team is claimed to be a form of discrimination.

Male national team players are in line to earn more for every win

There is a gulf in the potential average earnings per player for friendlies for the men's and women's national soccer teams



The USMNT earn a bonus – even if they lose

Like many national soccer federations, U.S. Soccer incentivizes its national team players in the form of performance-related bonuses, both in international friendlies and tournaments.

Interestingly, evidence from recent World Cups suggests that the men's team earned more for losing a World Cup qualifying match than the women's team did for winning the entire tournament. The bonus structure in place for international friendlies paints a similar picture: The men's team still received performance bonuses for losing friendly matches, while the women's team were only afforded a bonus for their wins. This led to a situation where the men could lose every single one of their friendlies in a year and still earn almost the same as the women who had won every single game with the USWNT.

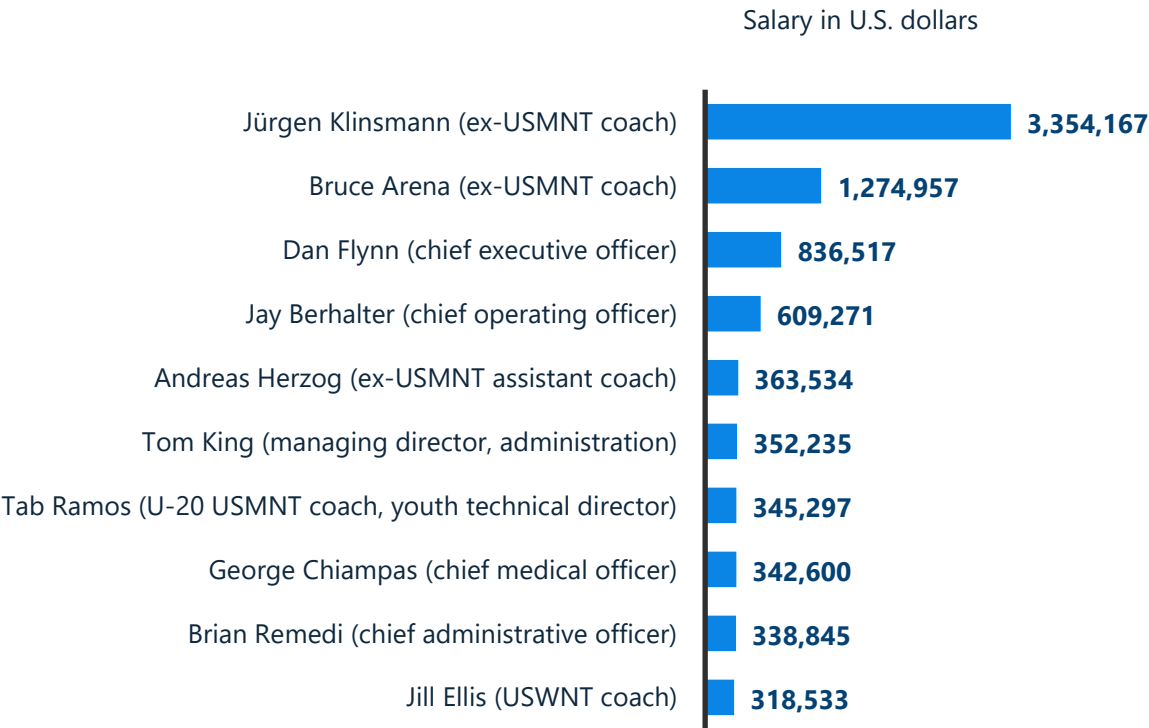
Even off the pitch, U.S. Soccer has questions to answer

One of the most successful international coaches of all time gets paid less than the youth coach

While the lawsuit focuses on the wages of the playing staff, the situation off the pitch is strikingly similar

Jill Ellis served as the head coach of the USWNT for five years from 2014 to 2019. Under her leadership, the United States won back-to-back World Cups and she was honored as the 2015 FIFA World Coach of the Year for Women’s Football. She was the first manager in history to win two Women’s World Cup titles and only the second national team coach across men’s and women’s soccer to win two consecutive titles since Italy’s men’s team won back-to-back titles in 1934 and 1938 under Vittorio Pozzo. She has since taken on the important role of development director of U.S. Soccer, overseeing the development of the next generation of soccer stars.

Ellis’ salary when compared to other employees does not reflect her achievements: Her head coach base salary was lower than those of five administrative positions, as well as being lower than that of the coach of the men’s U20 team. A direct comparison to the men’s national team coach is even more stark – Ellis earned just a tenth of the salary of Jürgen Klinsmann, who led the men’s national team from 2011 to 2016. The men’s team was knocked out by Belgium in the round of 16 of the 2014 World Cup, and Klinsmann was sacked after the U.S. came bottom of the regional qualification table for the 2018 World Cup.



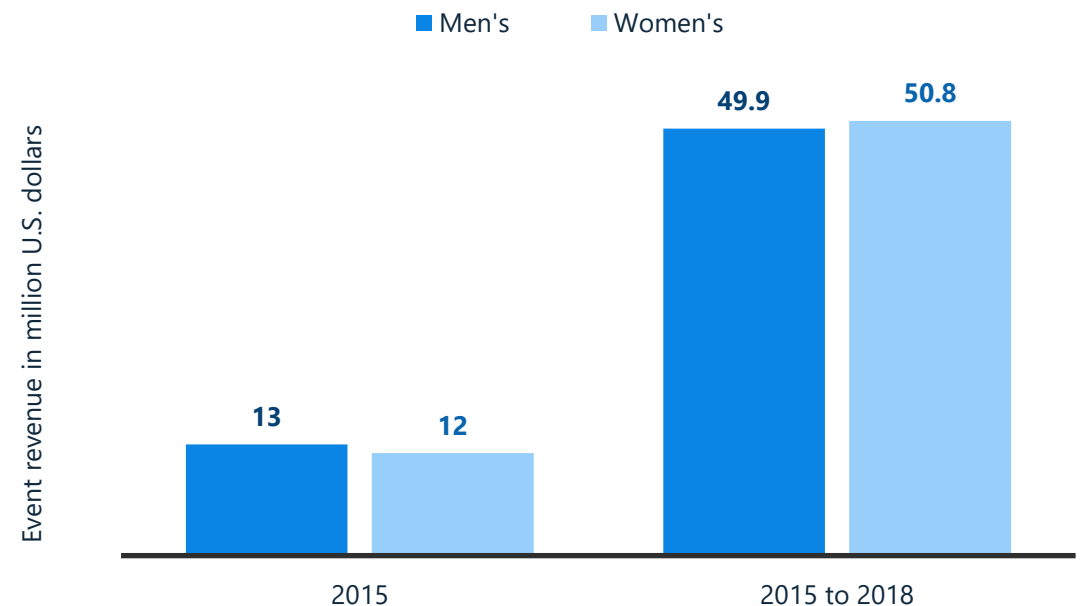
In recent years, the women's national team has earned more in event revenue than the men

What is the financial argument for closing the gender pay gap?

Much like the financial and marketing arguments used to explain the pay gap between domestic male and female professional sports leagues, U.S. Soccer responded to the lawsuit by stating that any differences in pay were down to “legitimate business reasons and not for any discriminatory or other unlawful purpose”. As can be seen with the example of the NBA and the WNBA, this argument may point to the systemwide underfunding of women’s sport. A business, much like a new sports league, cannot make money without first spending money. Indeed, the MLS, the men’s professional soccer league in North America, did not start making a profit until around 2005, almost 10 years after its foundation.

However, this financial argument does not seem to hold water when it comes to the national soccer teams. In line with the huge growth in support for the U.S. women’s national soccer team in recent years, its games have begun to generate marginally more revenue than the U.S. men’s games. This evidence comes from audited reports from the U.S. Soccer Federation itself and was a huge boost to the USWNT’s lawsuit – it not only seemed to demonstrate the equal financial value of the men’s and women’s teams to the federation, but it also illustrated the swell in support and attendance for

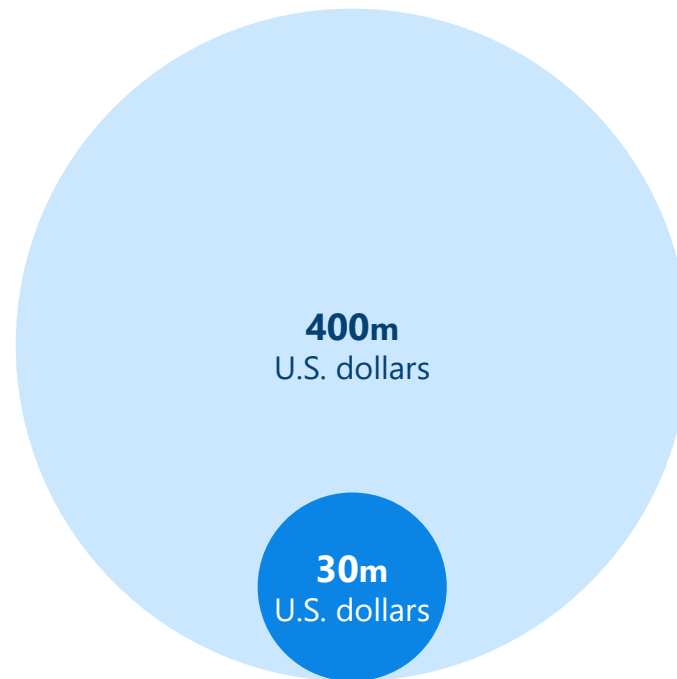
the women’s national team. The irony is that this ongoing lawsuit has elevated the women’s team to an even greater level, as they are now not only seen as a group of outstanding athletes, but also as role models championing an important cause.



On the biggest stage in international football, the gender pay gap is staggering

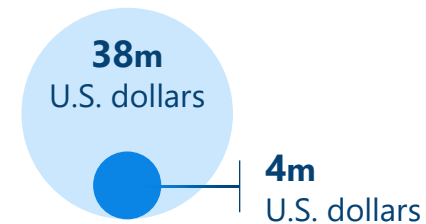


Total prize pool



- 2018 FIFA World Cup
- 2019 FIFA Women's World Cup

Winner's prize money



Viewership of the Women's World Cup final eclipsed the men

Despite the time zone difference, over 14 million tuned in to watch

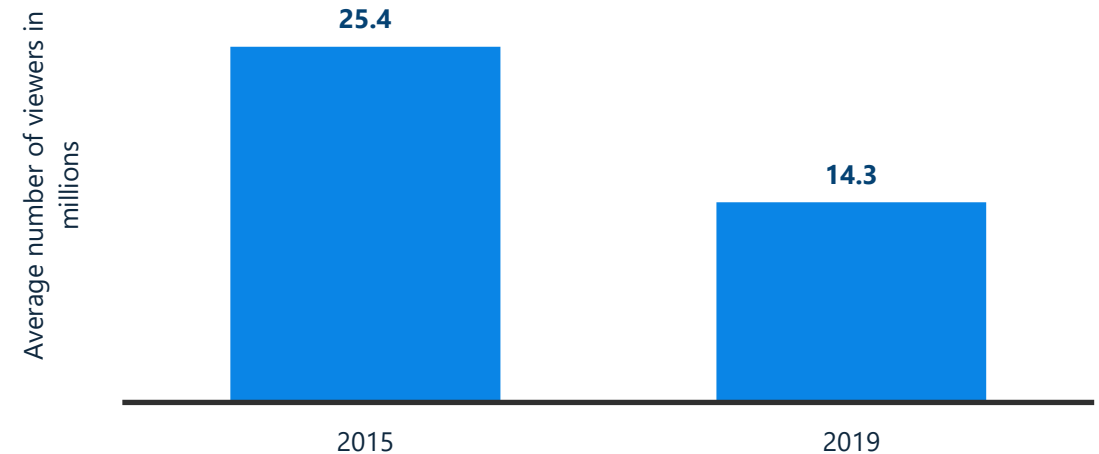
The success of the USWNT at the World Cup grips the nation

In 2015, the United States became the first team to win three Women's World Cup finals after beating Japan 5-2 in Vancouver. The showpiece event was watched by over 25 million viewers on FOX in the United States, making it the most watched soccer game ever – either men's or women's – on English-language television in the country. This figure was even higher than the NBA Finals and Game 7 of the MLB World Series in that year.

Having once again reached the final of the following World Cup in France in 2019, some 14.3 million Americans tuned in to watch the USWNT defeat the Netherlands 2-0. The drop in viewership from 2015 can be attributed to the time difference – the final aired early in the day in the United States, as opposed to the primetime slot of the 2015 Final. Nevertheless, the women's final attracted a 22 percent higher viewership than the 2018 Men's World Cup Final, demonstrating that it is currently the women's game in the U.S. where the business potential lies.

Despite these accomplishments, the USWNT took home just four million U.S. dollars in prize money out of a total pot of 30 million U.S. dollars for the tournament. In contrast, the prize fund for the men's World Cup in 2018 was

400 million U.S. dollars, with the champions France bagging 38 million U.S. dollars. With the viewing figures of the women's World Cup below, the comparison in the absolute number shows the potential for growth in revenue for the women's game as a whole.



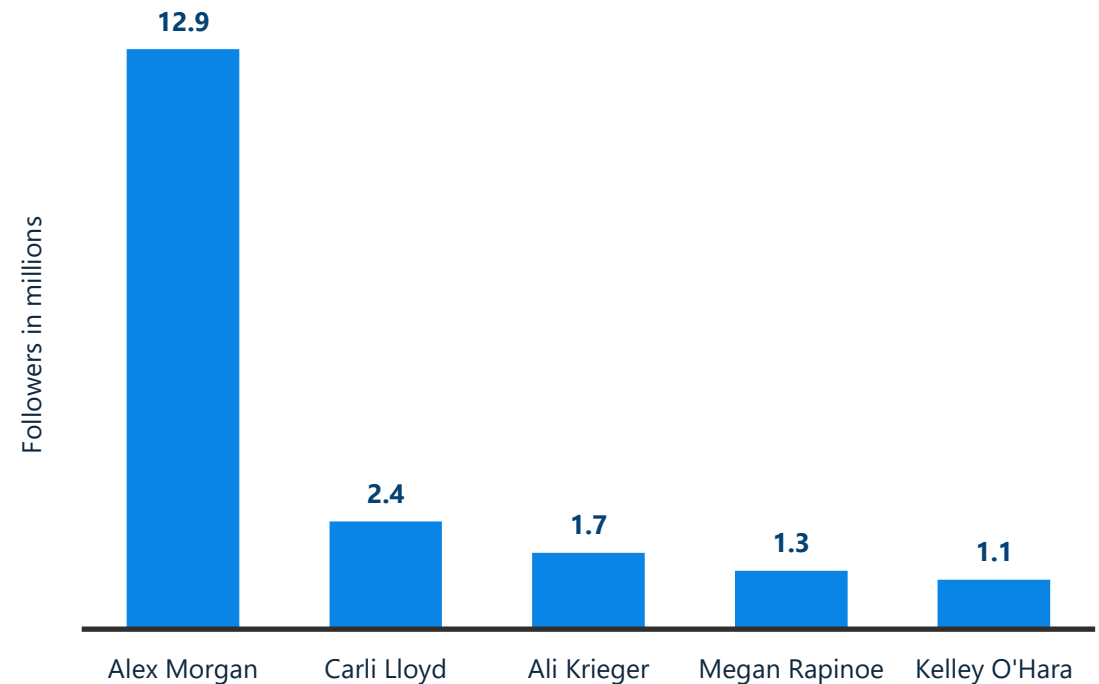
Some of the stars of the USWNT have a huge social media presence

Social media followers of some of the biggest stars in the team reach into the millions

The marketability of the USWNT players is rising

The exploits of the USWNT have certainly captured the hearts of the nation in recent years and have made stars of some of the squad members. Alex Morgan, who has scored over 100 times for her country, has a huge social media presence and is a household name in the United States. Her endorsements deals with Nike, McDonald's, Coca-Cola, and AT&T, among others, earned her a spot as the only soccer player in the top 15 highest paid female athletes worldwide, as well as being named as one of Time magazine's 100 most influential people for 2019. The co-captain of the national team is also planning to launch her own media company with the aim of focusing on women in sport and creating content for girls created by female athletes.

As well as breaking records on the field, the USWNT have been smashing them off the field: In the media frenzy surrounding the World Cup in 2019, Nike announced that the 2019 USA stadium women's home jersey was the top-selling soccer jersey of all time in one season on the website, even outperforming sales of the men's jerseys. This kind of commercial success highlights the cultural and economic impact of the USWNT in the United States.



What has been the impact of the lawsuit and what happens next?

The success of the USWNT on the pitch has been matched with a swell of support off the pitch. The fact that the event revenue for the women's national team outstrips the men's revenue, the record viewership, and the jersey sales associated with the women's team have all provided the foundation of the lawsuit that was presented by the players of the USWNT.

With the trial between the USWNT and U.S. Soccer ongoing and appeals to be lodged, it seems that there is no end in sight for this dispute. A glimmer of hope was provided by the men's national team in 2019, when it offered its support in the lawsuit against the federation and welcomed the idea of a revenue-sharing model: "The United States National Soccer Team Players Association fully supports the efforts of the U.S. Women's National Team Players to achieve equal pay. Specifically, we are committed to the concept of a revenue-sharing model to address the U.S. Soccer Federation's 'market realities' and find a way towards fair compensation." However, with the federation ultimately holding the purse strings to both the men's and women's national teams, there is still potential for many twists and turns in this saga.

One such twist was the surprise appointment of Cindy Parlow Cone as president of the United States Soccer Federation in March 2020. This

appointment came after the resignation of Carlos Cordeiro following public outcry about the federation's perceived sexist legal defense of its pay structure for its national teams. Parlow Cone is a former World Cup winner and two-time Olympic Gold medalist and has had first-hand experience as a player of the USWNT.

At a time when the language used by lawyers in the battle between the USWNT and the USSF was becoming increasingly incendiary, Parlow Cone stated: "I think it's one thing to argue that men and women play in different tournaments and play against different teams. It's altogether a different statement to say therefore, the women carry less responsibility or have less ability." Indeed, one of the main factors for Parlow Cone originally seeking a leadership position in the federation was her belief that the organization "needed a player's voice in the room when important decisions were being made." Her appointment can therefore be seen as a positive step towards championing the cause of women's soccer in the United States, but it remains to be seen whether this change in leadership at the top will have any direct bearing on the course of the lawsuit.

Spotlight: The curious case of Ada Hegerberg

How Norway came to pay their soccer stars the same

The very public feud between the USWNT and its federation has fueled wider debate in the footballing world about national federations' treatment of women's soccer. Another high-profile example which hit the headlines in the summer of 2017 was the case of Ada Hegerberg. The Norwegian footballer was widely considered one of the most exciting soccer talents in the world and had been scoring at a rate of more than one goal per game since joining Olympique Lyonnais in 2014. Hegerberg's continued success led her to become the first ever winner of the Ballon d'Or for women in December 2018.

However, back in 2017, despite being her country's poster girl for soccer, Hegerberg announced that she had decided to stop representing her national team in protest at the Norwegian Football Federation's treatment of women's soccer. She pointed to the fact that funding for the women's game in the country was less than a tenth of that for the men's game, despite attendances in the men's top division having hit an all-time low. In a recurring theme throughout women's sport, Hegerberg contested that women's soccer in the country and worldwide would not be able to grow and compete without initial investment, stating: "There are federations, there are clubs, there are men in high positions who have a responsibility to put women in the right place, too." The star striker's protest led to an

historic agreement, which saw Norway's soccer association sign a new deal with its players, leading to the men's and women's national teams receiving equal pay to represent their country. Other national federations have since followed suit, with the Brazilian Football Confederation (CBF) and the English Football Association (FA) both announcing in September 2020 that their respective women's national teams would receive the same pay as their male counterparts. Hegerberg, however, contends that there is still a long way to go and has not represented her country since.

The actions taken by the USWNT and individuals such as Ada Hegerberg highlight the underlying feelings of inequality experienced by female soccer players and female athletes as a whole. As more of these cases gain media traction, it will become increasingly difficult for sports federations not to address the way they treat their male and female employees.



04 Marketing women's sport

- Target audience
- Global events
- Brand outlook

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Brands underspend on women's sports because they don't understand the commercial viability of it. Oftentimes brands are shortsighted with their marketing spend, only interested in investing in a sport or athlete after they are deemed a 'success' or accomplish a 'big win'. However, I believe brands who invest now to change the future of women's sports will see the biggest payout as they will grow to be viewed more endemic to the space and true supporters.

“

—

Sade Ayodele

co-leader of the Digital Sports Group at Taylor

Is it time for brands to invest in the growing women's sport market?

Brands need to recognize women's sport as an investment for the future rather than a way to turn a quick profit. By understanding how to maximize the potential of the market and how it can be commercialized, the investment that they make now will pay dividends in the long run. As interest in female athletes and leagues increases to grow, as seen by the rising attendance figures and TV viewers, brands will be able to see the momentum that can be gained by tapping into this market at an early stage.

In order to achieve this success, brands need to address two things – who is their target audience and how do they market female athletes? It is clear that women consume content differently to men, and the same can be said for sport. While men use platforms like YouTube and Twitter to look for highlights, match statistics, and news about leagues and players, women follow teams on social media and engage with content that celebrate both in-game events and individual stories about the athletes.

Ultimately, consumers want to be able to create a connection with a brand and, when it comes to athletes, this means that people want to hear a story that resonates with them. In this respect, it does not matter whether the athlete is male or female, it is about their story and passion. These stories are even more significant when they are played out on a global stage, such as during a global event or competition. P&G's Secret brand tapped into this idea during the women's soccer World Cup in 2019, when

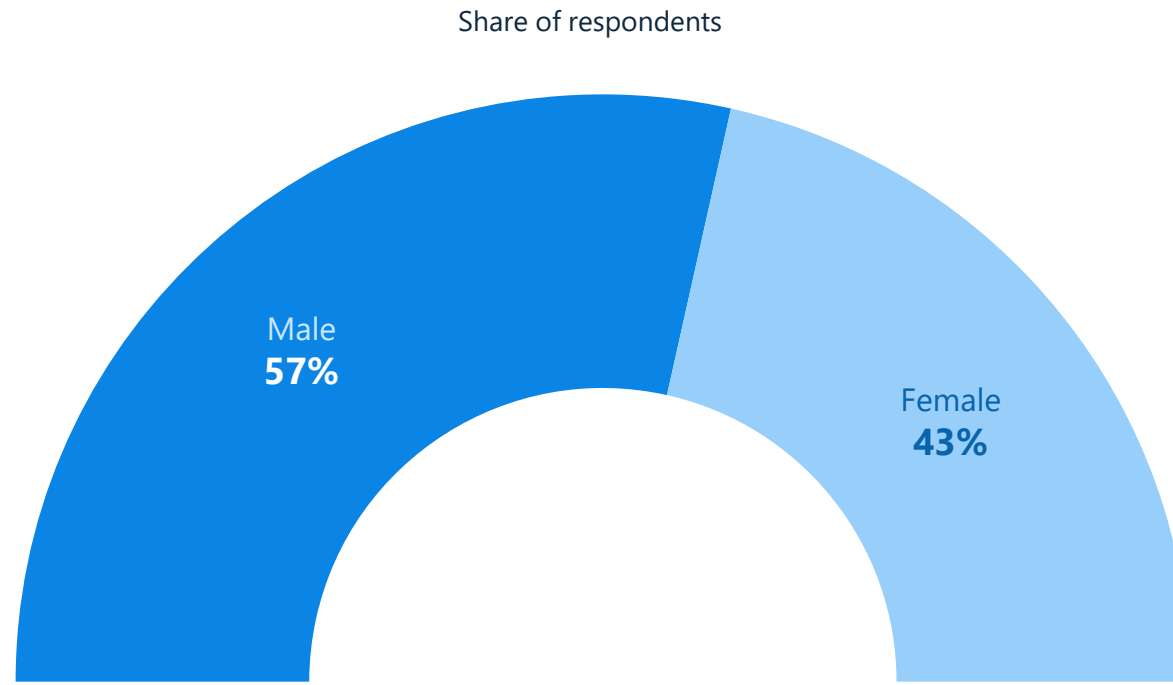
they partnered up with the USWNT. Their motto of "All Strength, No Sweat" went beyond just a deodorant and instead embodied the spirit of the women's soccer team and the idea of female empowerment.

More brands are now beginning to follow suit – Visa recently signed a seven-year deal to become the principal sponsor of the Women's Champions League, the highest domestic soccer competition in Europe. This made the company the first UEFA sponsor dedicated specifically to women's sport. In the United Kingdom, Barclays signed a multi-million-pound deal to become the main partner of the domestic soccer league, the Women's Super League (WSL). This deal was not only seen as a significant marketing step, but as a wider signal to support the sustainability of professionalism in women's sport.

It is also important to note the considerable purchasing power of women, as gender equality in wages continues to develop, and how this translates to the sports industry. With an ever-growing athleisure market, it is generally women who look for the latest styles for their children or the best activewear that not only looks great in the gym but is also comfortable to wear in their free time. There is a clear opportunity for brands to tap into this overlap between female sports fans and the rising prominence and appeal of female athletes.

Surprisingly, more men tune in to female pro leagues than women

Women's sport appeals almost equally to both genders, offering a huge potential market to advertisers and sponsors



Global women's sports leagues viewers tend to be younger

Marketers can tap into this younger, more online and socially-engaged demographic to sell their products

The younger the viewer, the higher the marketing potential?

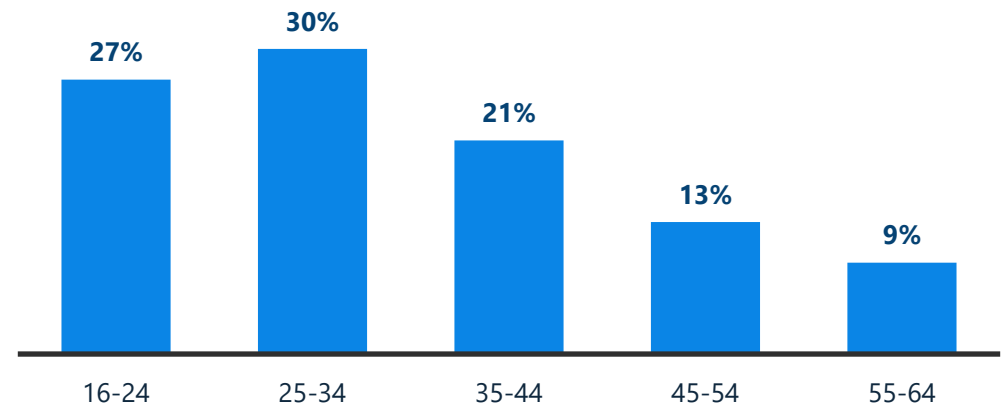
In today's online world, advertising and marketing is defined by social media campaigns and influencers. Given that the global audience of women's sports leagues tends to be younger and, by extension, more active online, as seen by the chart on the right, this presents a huge opportunity for marketers to tap into this potential. Fans have the ability to keep up-to-date with their favorite teams and engage with their sporting idols and other fans directly. This not only presents an opportunity for individual female athletes to grow their image and exposure online, but it allows marketers to use these rising online stars as the face of their company.

Nike is ahead of the curve when it comes to tapping into this lucrative market. The sportswear giant aired an ad during the 2019 Oscars which featured only female athletes and it used the social media clout of some of its most famous stars, such as Serena Williams and Simon Biles, to reinforce the empowering message on their social media channels, thereby exposing the brand to millions of fans.

The heart of this marketing strategy is not just selling a product but

reinforcing what the female athletes themselves represent. While the male athletes of marketing campaigns often stand for greatest and enduring success, such as Lionel Messi and Roger Federer, for example, the advertisements with female leads tend to portray a very tangible message of perseverance, strength, and overcoming challenges in a male-dominated world. Showing the consumer that the brand stands behind the message of the athletes appears to be the key to success.

Share of TV viewers of women's sports leagues worldwide in 2018, by age



Despite pulling in a smaller audience for the final, marketers favored the men's soccer World Cup

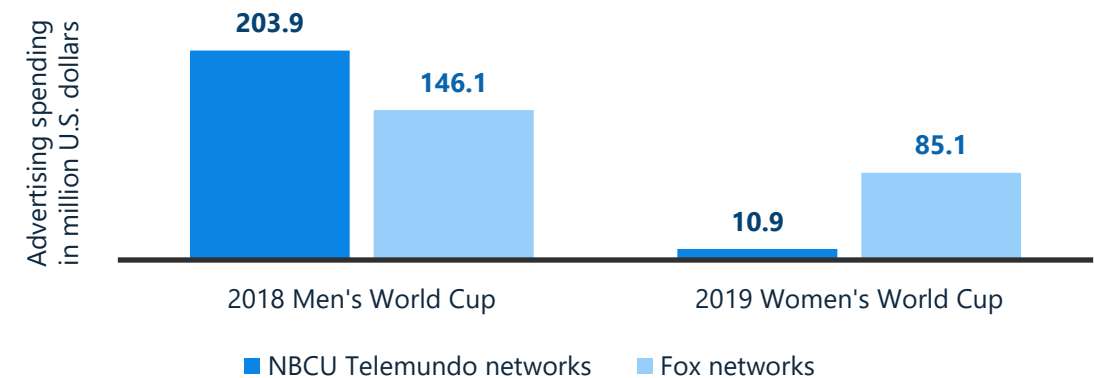
Advertisers are still misjudging the appeal of women's sporting events

The final of the 2019 Women's World Cup attracted a higher TV audience in the United States than the final of the men's event the previous year. However, it seems that advertisers missed the opportunity to cash in on this success, as the advertising spending throughout the entire women's event was significantly lower than during the men's event. By underestimating the appeal of women's sport, marketers are losing out on a huge potential market and, in some cases, the attention of consumers who would otherwise not engage in sporting events.

The growing appeal of women's sport can also be seen in the attendance at the 2020 ICC Women's T20 World Cup Final in cricket. The landmark event took place in one of Australia's largest cricket venues and was advertised as a celebration of women's sport. The match was played on International Women's Day and drew a crowd of over 86,000, making it the largest attendance ever for a men's or women's final in that format of cricket. By staging the tournament as a standalone event rather than parallel to the men's event, the tournament became purely a celebration of female athletes, rather than simply a women's alternative to the men's game. Coca-

Cola launched its “#PowerHasNoGender” campaign shortly before the World Cup and Puma worked with individual players from the Indian women's national team, showing just two examples of how big brands are starting to hone in on the appeal of women's sporting events.

TV advertising spending during the FIFA Women's and Men's World Cup on TV networks in the U.S.



During the women's soccer World Cup in 2019, brands enjoyed millions of engagements on social media

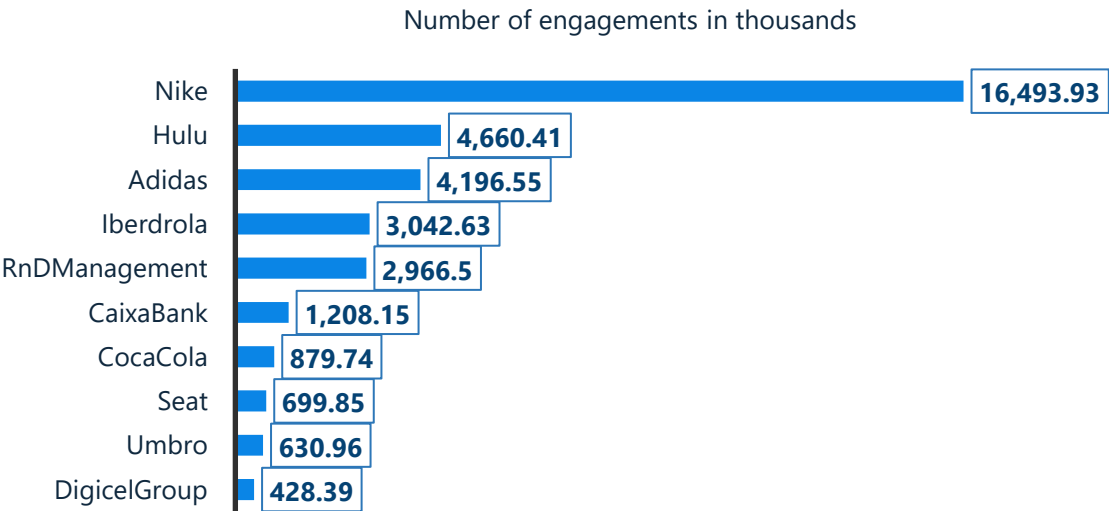
The power of a global tournament cannot be underestimated, but brands must be consistent

While female sports leagues have not yet reached the marketing heights of their male equivalents, there is nothing like a global event or tournament to get people excited and engaged. Given the ongoing and very public battle that the USWNT was waging with its own federation leading up to the 2019 World Cup, it comes as no surprise that brands looked to utilize this social media buzz to their advantage.

The clear winner in this advertising battle was Nike, the official kit sponsor of the U.S. team. Following the team's victory in the final, Nike released an inspirational video on its social media channels with the tagline "This team wins. Everyone wins." The message of the video went beyond simply success on the pitch and addressed the idea of female empowerment and shattering glass ceilings. By taking steps towards advocating empowerment and equality within the realm of sports and going beyond simply selling a product, Nike was able to achieve unrivalled engagements on its social media channels, as seen in the graph on the right.

However, the company also received backlash from its own female athletes, as it was exposed for reducing sponsorship payments during athletes'

pregnancies for not hitting performance-related targets. Although Nike has since confirmed that it will waive these targets for pregnant athletes, this highlights the need for unconditional brand support towards athletes, especially when it comes to female athletes. If a brand is to engage in, and support, the idea of female empowerment and women's sport, then its actions need to credibly reflect this. In today's social media-led marketing campaigns, any semblance of false support or ulterior motives is likely to invite a significant backlash.



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Marketers have got significant dollars and those dollars can significantly influence the outcomes. So, if you work with a team and you show you are putting your solidarity behind certain areas like gender balance, I think social and cultural change will happen.

“

—

Raja Rajamannar

Mastercard's chief marketing
and communications officer

What does the future hold and how can brands maximize the appeal of women's sport?

As long as women's sport remains underfunded and is not afforded the same exposure as men's sport, brands and companies have the opportunity to play a big part in building the foundations for women's sport to become a success in itself rather than having to cling onto the coat-tails of the men's game. While brands have the ability to dip in and out of men's sport as they see fit, given its likelihood to stay sustainable and profitable for some time, engaging in women's sport should not be seen as a token gesture, but rather a long-term commitment to redressing the gender imbalance. One such company that has taken on this challenge is Adidas. Following the USWNT's triumph in the 2019 World Cup, the sportswear company announced that all its sponsored athletes on the team would receive the same performance bonus payout as their male peers. It is public gestures like this that encourage other brands and advertisers to follow suit.

Brands must also recognize that blindly throwing money at the problem will not solve much. Instead, brands and companies need to actively support female athletes from the start. For sustainable progress, the success of a brand relies on supporting amateur and grassroots initiatives to nurture the next generation of female talents and female sports fans. It is not enough to simply jump on the bandwagon of global events and social media movements.

A brand can raise the profile of its athletes by adding value to a player, a team, or even a whole sport. By raising up its female stars to the same level as male athletes, a brand can benefit the sport as a whole, while simultaneously boosting its own profile as a brand for empowerment and change.

What makes women's sport unique is that a lot of the progress and change is driven by the athletes themselves. They have spent years climbing to the top of their game without the benefit of global sponsorship or media attention, and they are using their moment now to make their voices heard, even if this means standing up against their own associations or federations. Outstanding sportswomen such as Serena Williams and Megan Rapinoe have not only reached the pinnacle of their chosen sports, but they have become the spearheads of a movement for equality and female empowerment. Ultimately, women's sport is about much more than just the game. It has come to represent an entire movement fighting for equality and celebrating the empowerment and strength of women. For any brand to tap into this growing market, it needs to be willing to champion these causes in actions and words.

Glossary

Title IX

A federal civil rights law passed in 1972 to end gender discrimination in federally funded programs.

NCAA

The National Collegiate Athletic Association is the body in charge of student athletes and athletic programs.

NFL

The National Football League is a male professional American football league in the United States.

NBA

The National Basketball Association is a male professional basketball league in North America.

WNBA

The Women's National Basketball Association is a female professional basketball league in the United States.

NHL

The National Hockey League is a male professional ice hockey league in North America.

MLS

Major League Soccer is a men's professional soccer league in North America.

Grand Slam

The four main tennis tournaments each year – the Australian Open, the French Open, the U.S. Open, and Wimbledon.

ATP

The Association of Tennis Professionals is the governing body for men's professional tennis.

WTA

The Women's Tennis Association is the governing body for women's professional tennis.

PGA

The Professional Golfers' Association is the governing body for men's professional golf.

LPGA

The Ladies Professional Golf Association is the governing body for women's professional golf.

Golf Major

The four main men's golf championships each year – the Masters, the PGA Championship, the U.S. Open, and The Open Championship.

USWNT

The United States women's national soccer team.

USMNT

The United States men's national soccer team.

USSF

The United States Soccer Federation.

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WTA

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